Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Deuteronomy

Deuteronomy 1:1

- These are the words that Moses spoke: Although the book of Deuteronomy follows the pattern of a covenant or treaty document, it is mainly a series of speeches. Moses delivered these speeches to the whole assembly of Israel.
- Arabah: This is a common word usually translated as "wilderness" or "desert." In general, the Arabah refers to the Great Rift Valley. This valley stretches from the Sea of Galilee south to the Red Sea, also called the Gulf of Aqaba. In this passage, the word refers to the dry land near the lower Jordan River, just north of the Dead Sea.

Deuteronomy 1:1–5

Ancient Near Eastern treaty texts usually began with a brief section introducing the partners in the covenant, their relationship to each other, and their immediate ancestry. This introduction provides information primarily about the social and geographic setting.

Deuteronomy 1:2

- The distance from Mount Horeb in the southern Sinai Peninsula to Kadesh-barnea in the north is only 241 kilometers (150 miles) (see study note on 1:19). The large Hebrew population could have easily traveled this distance in eleven days if they had traveled directly. Yet, their rebellion against the Lord caused a 38-year delay and a circular route (see 2:14; Numbers 14:34).
- Horeb (or Sinai): Deuteronomy uses this name for the holy mountain where God gave the covenant. The name likely has a connection to a word meaning "drought" or "devastation." This suggests the harsh conditions the people of Israel encountered.
- The way of Mount Seir was the route from Mount Horeb to Mount Seir. Seir is another name for Edom. It was east-southeast of the Dead Sea. The usual route took travelers through the Arabah north from the Gulf of Aqaba and then west to Kadesh-barnea. This is 97 kilometers (60 miles) southwest of the Dead Sea.

Deuteronomy 1:4

- The Amorites were a Semitic people, related to the Canaanites by language. They first lived in what is now north-central Syria. They later moved into Canaan, settling on both sides of the Jordan River, mainly in the hill country.

During Israel's conquest, many Amorites lived in Transjordan (the region east of the Jordan River), north of the Arnon River. Their capital was at Heshbon (see also study note on Numbers 21:13). The Israelites had already displaced many of them before this time (Numbers 22:21–35).

- Bashan was another Amorite area, located north of the Yarmuk River and east of the Sea of Galilee. It was famous for its valuable livestock (compare Psalm 22:12; Ezekiel 39:18; Amos 4:1 and study note). Its capital was Ashtaroth.
- The kings Sihon and Og are not known outside the Bible (see Numbers 21:21–35).

Deuteronomy 1:6–4.40

Secular treaties (formal agreements between nations) often included a section about the past relationship between the two partners. This section reviewed what had happened before the agreement.

In this case, the purpose was to review Israel's successes and failures since the exodus from Egypt. It reminded the people that God had kept his word, even when they did not obey him.

To prepare the Israelites for life in Canaan, Moses reminded them about life in Egypt, their 40 years of wandering in the wilderness, and their past mistakes. He warned them to obey God's covenant. He assured them that God's grace would follow them as they learned to trust and obey the Lord.

Deuteronomy 1:7

- The hill country included the interior areas of Canaan, where the Amorites also lived (see 1:4; Numbers 13:29; Joshua 10:6). The Canaanites once lived all over Palestine, but the Amorites forced them into the valleys and lowlands.
- the foothills (Hebrew the Shephelah): This is a term still used in modern Israel for the area between the hills of Judah and the coastal plain. This region is known for orchards and vineyards.
- the Negev: This large desert area is south of Canaan. The Hebrew word can also mean "the south."

Deuteronomy 1:8

possess the land (literally acquire it as an inheritance): The land already belonged to Israel because God had promised it to their ancestors centuries earlier (Genesis 15:18–21; 26:3; Exodus 23:31). Israel was not taking new territory from rightful owners but was reclaiming their own land.

Deuteronomy 1:9–18

See Exodus 18:13–27.

Deuteronomy 1:10

as numerous as the stars: This figure of speech is an exaggeration. Abraham's descendants did not match the actual number of stars in the universe, but they exceeded the stars visible to the naked eye. Moses meant that God had started fulfilling his promises to Abraham (see Genesis 15:5; 22:17). He did this by making Israel numerous, bringing them to the promised land, and preparing them to conquer it.

Deuteronomy 1:13

respected men: These people had lives and reputations that were beyond criticism, even when examined closely.

Deuteronomy 1:15

thousands ... hundreds ... fifties ... tens: These numbers describe a common way to organize an army. Soldiers were grouped under leaders of one thousand, one hundred, fifty, and ten. Because this was a normal military system, some of these officials were likely military officers (see 1 Samuel 8:12; 22:7; 2 Samuel 18:1).

Deuteronomy 1:16–17

Show no partiality (literally Do not notice faces): People appearing before the court should be treated as though they were wearing a mask to conceal their identity. Judges were not to be influenced by rich and powerful persons in the community but were to judge on the basis of God's own impartiality (10:17) and treat all persons equally under the law.

Deuteronomy 1:19

Kadesh-barnea was a large oasis with many wells and springs. It was about 80 kilometers (50 miles) south of Beersheba, which was the traditional southern point of Israel (see 2 Samuel 3:10; 1 Chronicles 21:2).

Deuteronomy 1:19–25

See Numbers 13.

Deuteronomy 1:24–25

Eshcol means "cluster." Grapes were the fruit grown there (see Numbers 13:23–27).

Deuteronomy 1:26–46

See Numbers 14.

Deuteronomy 1:28

Anak was known as a man of very large size (2:10, 21; 9:2; Numbers 13:33). Goliath may have been one of Anak's descendants (1 Samuel 17:4). Some of Anak's family moved to the Philistine coastal plain (Deuteronomy 2:23; Joshua 11:21–23; 15:14; 1 Chronicles 20:4–8).

Deuteronomy 1:30

will fight for you: This phrase refers to the defeat of the Canaanite nations. God would start the battle, lead it, fight it, and ensure victory. The only other use of this phrase refers to God's actions during the exodus (Exodus 14:14).

Deuteronomy 1:31

God's gentle care as a father showed his special agreement with Israel (Exodus 4:22; Hosea 11:1–4; see also Matthew 6:26–33; John 14:21; Acts 13:18; Romans 8:15–17; 1 Peter 1:2–3; 1 John 3:1). Israel was God's child because they came from Abraham and because God chose and adopted Israel from all nations (Deuteronomy 14:2; Exodus 19:4–6).

This parent-child language is similar to language in secular covenant texts (ancient treaty documents between kings). In these treaties, a great king often called a smaller ruler, called a vassal (a ruler under his authority), his "son." This word showed a close relationship and loyalty between them.

Deuteronomy 1:33

Sometimes God showed his presence in visible ways. These appearances are called theophanies (visible signs that God is present). The pillar of fire and the pillar of cloud were examples of this.

These signs assured the people that God was with them and that he was powerful. When the pillar moved ahead, the people followed. They trusted that God would lead them safely to their destination (Exodus 13:21–22; 14:24; Psalm 18:9–10).

Deuteronomy 1:36

Caleb was one of the twelve spies Moses sent to assess the political and military situation in Canaan. Only Caleb and Joshua reported that God would help Israel conquer Canaan (Numbers 13:6, 8, 16, 30). Caleb later became the father-in-law of Othniel, Israel's first judge (Judges 1:13).

Because of his faithfulness, Caleb received the area around Hebron as his inheritance, and he expelled the Anakites (see Joshua 14:12–15; Judges 1:20).

Deuteronomy 1:37

The LORD was also angry with me on your account: Moses became frustrated with rebellious Israel. He disobeyed God by hitting the rock instead of speaking to it (Numbers 20:10–13).

Deuteronomy 1:44

Hormah is probably modern Khirbet el-Meshash. This site is eleven kilometers (seven miles) southeast of Beersheba. The ancient name comes from the verb kharam, which means to "devastate" or "annihilate." The Israelites did devastate Hormah (Numbers 14:45; 21:3).

Deuteronomy 2:1

Mount Seir was a mountainous area north of the Gulf of Aqaba, east of the Arabah and the Dead Sea (see study note on 1:1).

The Horites first settled there (Genesis 14:6). Many scholars now identify the Horites with the Hurrians. Ancient texts describe the Hurrians as traveling traders and explorers. They lived in many parts of the ancient Near East.

Over time, the descendants of Esau replaced the Horites in Mount Seir (Deuteronomy 2:22). The region was called Edom (meaning "red"), possibly because of the area's rose-red stone.

Deuteronomy 2:2–25

Numbers 21:10–20 covers the same time period.

Deuteronomy 2:5

I have given: God's gift of a promised land was not only for Israel. He also gave lands to Edom, Moab, Ammon, and the Caphtorites (2:9; 2:19; 2:22–23).

God chose Israel as a special nation (1:31; see also 7:6; 14:2; Exodus 19:5). Yet, he is the God of all nations and has a place and purpose for each one (Deuteronomy 32:8; Acts 17:26). This is true even for those who do not acknowledge his rule (Romans 1:16–23).

Deuteronomy 2:8

- our brothers: Isaac had two sons: Esau and Jacob. Esau was the firstborn. Jacob took Esau's birthright and blessing as the firstborn (Genesis 25:27–34; 27:1–36). This led to intense hostility between Esau and Jacob and their descendants. Yet, Israel still recognized and honored their kinship.

Out of brotherly loyalty, if not affection, Israel passed by Edom and did not fight the Edomites (see Numbers 20:14–21).

- Arabah road: See study note on Deuteronomy 1:1.
- Elath and Ezion-geber were twin port cities on the Red Sea. They later harbored the merchant ships of King Solomon, Jehoshaphat, and Uzziah (1 Kings 9:26; 1 Kings 22:48; 2 Kings 14:22).

Deuteronomy 2:9

- Lot was Abraham's nephew and Isaac's cousin. God destroyed Sodom, Gomorrah, and other nearby cities. Then Lot and his two unmarried daughters took shelter in a cave east of the Dead Sea (see Genesis 19:30–38). Lot's daughters got their father so drunk that he had sexual relations with them.

Their children became the nations of Moab and Ammon. Because they were relatives of Israel, they would not disturb the Moabites. King David's great-grandmother Ruth was from Moab (Ruth 1:4). David sent his family to Moab for safety when Saul chased him (1 Samuel 22:3–5).

- Ar was probably the capital of Moab.

Deuteronomy 2:10

The Emites also lived at Shaveh-kiriathaim (Genesis 14:5). This was 16 kilometers (about 10 miles) east of the Dead Sea's north end.

Deuteronomy 2:11

The Rephaim lived near Ashteroth-karnaim (Genesis 14:5), which might be modern Tell Ashtarah. This is directly east of the Sea of Galilee (see Deuteronomy 1:4).

Deuteronomy 2:12

just as Israel drove out: The Hebrew does not include the phrase the people of Canaan. This passage is often cited as a later addition to Deuteronomy because it seems to presuppose the conquest under Joshua. However, it refers in part to the defeat of peoples east of the Jordan, such as the Amorites under King Sihon and King Og (3:12–17).

Deuteronomy 2:13

The ravine of the Brook of Zered marked the border between Moab and Edom. It began in the highlands of Mount Seir. From there, it flowed down to the southeastern end of the Dead Sea.

Deuteronomy 2:19

The Ammonites, like the Moabites, descended from Lot and his daughters' relationship (see study note on 2:9). For most of their history, the Ammonites lived south and east of the Jabbok River. Their capital was Rabbath Ammon, now known as Amman, Jordan. David arranged for the death of Uriah, Bathsheba's husband, during the attack on this city (2 Samuel 11:1, 14–21).

Deuteronomy 2:20–21

The Zamzummites are probably the same as the Zuzites (Genesis 14:5). God removed them from the land earlier so the Ammonites could live there. The God of Israel is also the God of the entire earth. He cares about all nations and has a place and purpose for each one.

Deuteronomy 2:23

- The Caphtorites were descendants of Noah's son Ham and originally came from Crete. This is a large island south of the Greek peninsula. Scholars usually identify the Caphtorites with the Philistines (see Genesis 10:6–14; 1 Chronicles 1:8–12). The Philistines arrived in Canaan through two separate movements.

One movement happened during the time of the Hebrew patriarchs (see study note on Genesis 21:32). The other movement began around 1200 BC (see study notes on Joshua 13:2; Judges 3:3). This passage probably refers to the earlier settlement.

- The Avvites were native to the lower Mediterranean coastal plain. The early wave of Philistines replaced them in Gaza (compare Joshua 13:2–4).

Deuteronomy 2:24

- The Arnon Valley is a deep canyon formed by the Arnon River. It sometimes marked the border between Moab and Edom (see Numbers 21:13). The river starts deep in the Arabian Desert and flows into the Dead Sea along its eastern shore.
- Sihon the Amorite controlled the area east of the Jordan River, north of the Arnon River, and south of the Ammonite territories (see Numbers 21:21–35). No ancient records mention him except the Bible. His capital, Heshbon, was probably about 24 kilometers (15 miles) southwest of Rabbath Ammon. It is usually considered to be the same place as the impressive ruins at Tell Hesban.

Deuteronomy 2:26

The Wilderness of Kedemoth might be the area north of the Arnon Gorge between Dibon and Mattanah (Joshua 13:18; 21:37).

Deuteronomy 2:26–37

See Numbers 21:21–32.

Deuteronomy 2:30

God had made his spirit stubborn and his heart obstinate (literally God hardened his spirit and strengthened his heart): Like Pharaoh, Sihon refused to repent and encountered God's wrath (see Exodus 7:13). God knew that showing more grace to these rulers would be of no use.

There is mystery in how people harden their own hearts (for example, Exodus 7:13, 22; 8:15) and how God hardens hearts (for example, Exodus 4:21; 7:3; 9:12). What is clear is that God asks for repentance and is ready to forgive. Yet, when people keep ignoring or rejecting him, they may become unable to hear and obey God (see "Hardened Hearts" Theme Note; Romans 1:21–28; 9:17–24).

Deuteronomy 2:34

devoted to destruction (Hebrew kharam): The Hebrew term means dedicating things or people entirely to the Lord. This could be either by destroying them or offering them. The purpose was to protect the Lord's holiness. It also guarded Israel from pagan idolatry (see also Leviticus 27:28–29).

Deuteronomy 2:36

- Aroer stood on the north rim of the Arnon Gorge. It was about five kilometers (three miles) from Dibon. Aroer marked the southern border of the Amorite kingdom (3:12; 4:48; Joshua 12:2; 13:9, 16, 25).
- The identity of the town located in the gorge itself is not certain.
- Gilead lay north of the Jabbok River. This river formed the northern border of the Amorites under King Sihon. Gilead was famous for its balm (a healing ointment) and other fragrant spices (Jeremiah 8:22; 46:11).

Deuteronomy 2:37

- Like the Moabites, the Ammonites were relatives of Israel and must be left alone (see 2:9).
- The Jabbok River, a major tributary of the Jordan River, marked the border between Gilead to the north and the Amorite kingdom of Sihon to the

south. The Ammonites lived east and south of the Jabbok (see 2:19). Jacob wrestled with a stranger at night somewhere at the Jabbok (see Genesis 32:22–32).

Deuteronomy 3:1–11

See Numbers 21:33–35.

Deuteronomy 3:4

Argob may be another name for Bashan. It may also refer to a specific area within Bashan that had many towns and people.

Deuteronomy 3:8

Mount Hermon is the southernmost peak in the Anti-Lebanon Mountains, northeast of the Sea of Galilee. At 2,834 meters (9,300 feet) above sea level, it is the highest peak. On a clear day, you can see this impressive landmark from many kilometers away.

Deuteronomy 3:9

The alternative names Sirion and Senir suggest that the Israelites may have given Hermon its name later. Hermon is apparently related to the verb kharam, which means "to destroy" (see study note on 2:34). It may describe the destruction summarized in 3:3–7.

Deuteronomy 3:11

- His bed was probably wooden and decorated with iron. Another possibility is that the Hebrew word refers to a sarcophagus (a stone coffin). In that case, the object may have been a burial container rather than an ordinary bed.
- Rabbah is the same city as Rabbath Ammon (see study note on Deuteronomy 2:19). The text suggests that this object could still be seen there when Deuteronomy was written.

This may mean that some kind of public display existed in Rabbah. People could look at this artifact as a reminder of the past.

Deuteronomy 3:12

- The Reubenites and Gadites asked Moses if they could settle east of the Jordan River instead of in Canaan. Moses agreed to their request (Numbers 32:1–5).
- Aroer: See study note on Deuteronomy 2:36.

Deuteronomy 3:12–20

See Numbers 32.

Deuteronomy 3:13

- The half-tribe of Manasseh asked for the same land as the tribes of Reuben and Gad. Moses accepted their request (see 3:12). Gad and Reuben settled between the Arnon River and the middle of Gilead (see 2:24; 2:36). Manasseh captured the land north of that, including Bashan (see 3:1).
- The Rephaites were a giant people related to the Anakites (see 2:11). This passage notes that they were native to Bashan.

Deuteronomy 3:14

- Jair was a descendant of Manasseh through Makir and Gilead (1 Chronicles 2:22).
- The Geshurites and Maacathites were small kingdoms in Bashan. They were located along the western side of the Golan Heights, east of the Sea of Galilee. These groups lived near the land that Israel later controlled.
- Havvoth-jair was the name given to Argob after Jair brought it under Israelite control (see Deuteronomy 3:4).

Deuteronomy 3:15

Machir was a clan in the tribe of Manasseh (Numbers 26:29). Jair was a relative of this clan (1 Chronicles 2:21–23). The Machir clan settled south of Bashan in northern Gilead (see Deuteronomy 3:13).

Deuteronomy 3:17

- from Chinnereth to the Sea of the Arabah (the Salt Sea): The Hebrew name for the beautiful Sea of Galilee is Chinnereth. This name might come from the word chinnor ("harp"), because the lake is shaped somewhat like a harp.
- the Sea of the Arabah (Hebrew Yam Hammelakh, meaning "Salt Sea"): It is also called the Dead Sea (see study note on 1:1). The water has a very high mineral content, about 30 percent, which makes it difficult for most life to survive.
- Pisgah is a section of the Abarim mountain range. Its most prominent peak is Mount Nebo. Moses viewed the promised land from there, and he died there (see 34:1).

Deuteronomy 3:21

The LORD will do the same: Israel's military success under the leadership of Moses would continue under Joshua because the Lord promised to stay with them.

Deuteronomy 3:21–29

See Numbers 20:2–13 and Psalm 106:32–33.

Deuteronomy 3:24

For what god: Moses was not suggesting that other gods truly exist. He was affirming that only the Lord is God.

This question declares the uniqueness of the Lord. It states that no one and nothing else, whether real or imagined, can rival him.

The statement emphasizes that the Lord alone has supreme power and authority.

Deuteronomy 3:29

Beth-peor was also known as Baal-peor (4:3) or simply Peor (Numbers 23:28; Joshua 22:17). Beth-peor became the burial place of Moses (Deuteronomy 34:6). At that place the false prophet Balaam had earlier attempted to curse Israel on behalf of Balak, king of Moab (Numbers 23:27–24:25).

Deuteronomy 4:1

The terms statutes and ordinances in Deuteronomy refer to the covenant rules and the detailed application of the main principles of God's law (for example, 4:5, 8, 14, 45; 5:1, 31; see also study note on 4:44).

Deuteronomy 4:1–40

Moses gave a long speech to the Israelites because of their recent failures and what he thought would happen in Canaan.

Deuteronomy 4:3

Baal was the Canaanite god associated with the fertility of the soil and of human and animal life. Local pagan worship centers linked Baal with their own shrines and cultic rituals, as with the god of Peor (see 3:29).

Deuteronomy 4:6

Observe ... wisdom and intelligence: Wisdom is linked to obedience. Obeying the Lord is the essence of wisdom (see 10:12–13; Proverbs 1:7; 9:10; 15:33). If God's people were wise and careful enough to keep the Lord's perfect covenant, the nations would see this and be amazed. Their obedience would display God's wisdom to the world.

Deuteronomy 4:8

Israel's laws were righteous and fair because they came from God.

Deuteronomy 4:11

black clouds and deep darkness: These contrasting displays of God's presence (theophanies; see study note on 1:33) show how he revealed himself while also remaining hidden (see Exodus 19:16–19).

Deuteronomy 4:13

- The covenant is the main theological idea in Deuteronomy and perhaps in the whole Old Testament. A covenant was a legal agreement between two or more parties. Each side accepted clear and binding responsibilities. In other words, both sides agreed to keep certain promises.

The covenant at Sinai gave written form to this relationship between the Lord and Israel (Exodus 20–23). In Deuteronomy, Moses explained and expanded this covenant for a new generation. This generation was about to enter, conquer, and live in the promised land.

- The Ten Commandments (literally the ten words, "decalogue") are at the center of the covenant. Because of their importance, they are sometimes treated as equal to the covenant itself.

The first four commandments guide Israel's relationship with God. The last six commandments guide relationships between people.

- two tablets of stone: In the ancient world, people made copies of legal documents for all parties involved. Covenant documents followed this same pattern.

God's copy was written on two stone tablets. The tablets were placed inside the ark of the covenant in the sanctuary (see Exodus 25:16, 21; 31:18; 40:20; compare Deuteronomy 31:26). Israel's copy was written in the books of Exodus and Deuteronomy (Exodus 20:1–17; Deuteronomy 5:6–21).

Deuteronomy 4:15

form: No human-made image could fully show the glory and power of the invisible God (Nehemiah 9:20; Isaiah 63:10–14; Zechariah 4:6; John 4:24).

If people made a visible form of the Lord, they might worship that form instead of worshiping God himself.

Deuteronomy 4:16

idol: Idolatry limited the Lord to what a human artist could imagine and make. But the Lord is greater than anything a person can create.

Israel was not to make idols shaped like any of God's creatures (4:17–18). This command protected the people from false worship.

Idols and images could lead people to worship created things instead of the Creator (5:8–9; Romans 1:23–25). Instead of honoring the God who made everything, they might honor something he made.

Deuteronomy 4:19

- host of heaven: This phrase refers to stars and other celestial bodies. People once thought they represented gods. Instead, they serve God, who named them to mark times and seasons (Genesis 1:14–19; Isaiah 40:26).
- The LORD your God has apportioned: Instead of worshiping these celestial bodies, God required the people of Israel to understand that God created them to serve humankind (Genesis 1:28).

Deuteronomy 4:20

- An iron-smelting furnace refines metal ores, separating pure metal from waste. Similarly, Israel's experiences in Egypt made the Israelites more spiritually and morally pure.
- the people of His inheritance: Israel was God's inheritance. As a result, the Israelites were ready to enter, conquer, and occupy the land (compare 1 Peter 2:9–12).

Deuteronomy 4:24

God does not have jealousy in the same way humans do. Human jealousy can be selfish or petty. That is not true of God.

The phrase a jealous God shows that God is unique and demands exclusive worship (6:15; Leviticus 10:2; Numbers 16:35). He alone is worthy of worship. He will not share his glory with idols or false gods.

The Hebrew word can mean "jealous" or "zealous" (strongly committed). It describes God's deep commitment to his own honor and rule. God actively protects his reputation as the ruler over all.

Deuteronomy 4:26

Heaven and earth would testify against Israel if the people were unfaithful to the Lord. In a covenant partnership, both parties were accountable for their promises of loyalty and commitment. They promised in front of witnesses (Isaiah 1:2–7; Micah 6:1–8).

In Deuteronomy, nature serves as that witness (see also Deuteronomy 30:19).

Deuteronomy 4:27

scatter you: One of the curses of the covenant warned that God would scatter Israel among the nations if they broke the covenant (28:64). This meant the people would be forced to leave their land and live far away, even to distant parts of the earth.

This judgment happened more than once in Israel's history:

- The Assyrians conquered the northern kingdom in 722 BC.
- The Babylonians conquered Judah from 605 to 586 BC.
- Later, the Romans destroyed Jerusalem in AD 70.

Deuteronomy 4:30

in later days: Israel would one day return from exile and from being scattered among the nations (see 30:1–10; Leviticus 26:40–45; Jeremiah 31:27–34; Ezekiel 36:22–31).

Deuteronomy 4:34

a strong hand and an outstretched arm: These phrases describe God in human terms. This way of speaking is called anthropomorphism (using human features to describe God; see study note on 8:2).

These words do not mean that God has a physical body like a human. Instead, they show God's great power. They point to his sovereign strength in rescuing Israel from slavery in Egypt.

Deuteronomy 4:36

great fire: God revealed the covenant law at Mount Sinai with an amazing and terrifying display of power and glory. It was like the eruption of a great volcano (see study note on 1:33; see Exodus 3:1–4; 24:16–18).

Deuteronomy 4:39

The Lord is unique. There is no other God besides him.

This teaching repeats the first two commandments (5:6–8; Exodus 20:2–4). It also prepares the way for the Shema (a Hebrew word that means "Hear"). The Shema begins with the words, "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is One" (Deuteronomy 6:4–5).

God's uniqueness needed to be clearly stated. The nations around Israel worshiped many gods. Israel was called to worship the Lord alone.

Deuteronomy 4:40

live long: The promise of long life meant more than a long life for one individual. It described Israel's continued stay in the promised land.

Deuteronomy 4:41–43

When Israel settled in Canaan and began living in cities, serious crimes such as homicide required legal decisions. Disputes could not be settled by private revenge. They needed judges to decide each case.

The law provided cities of refuge to protect people accused of killing someone. These cities gave safety from immediate revenge and allowed time for a fair trial. The first cities were set apart east of the Jordan River. Later, others were set apart in Canaan (see Numbers 35:9–28).

The laws about these cities appear again in Deuteronomy 19:1–13. They are mentioned here because Moses had just promised long and secure life in the land (4:40). Protecting the innocent from false accusations helped make that promise possible.

Deuteronomy 4:41–49

Moses was ready to present the covenant with full authority. He spoke as the Lord's chosen leader and teacher.

This section connects two parts of Deuteronomy. First, Moses reviewed Israel's past journey (1:6–4:40). Next, he began to explain the covenant itself in detail (5:1–26:19).

Deuteronomy 4:43

- Bezer is probably modern Umm al-'Amad. Bezer was 1.6 kilometers (about six miles) east of Heshbon.
- Ramoth in Gilead was 56 kilometers (35 miles) east-southeast of the Sea of Galilee.
- The town of Golan was about 64 kilometers (40 miles) north of Ramoth in Gilead.

Deuteronomy 4:44

law (Hebrew Torah): This word comes from the verb yarah, which means "to teach." Its basic meaning is "instruction." The Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) translates this word as "law." In this passage, the word introduces the main section of teaching that follows in Deuteronomy (see study note on 5:1–26:19).

Deuteronomy 4:48

Mount Siyion: The Sidonians used the name Siyion for Mount Hermon.

Deuteronomy 4:49

the Arabah on the east side of the Jordan and as far as the Sea of the Arabah: The word Arabah can mean "wilderness" or "dry wasteland." It usually refers to the Great Rift Valley south of the Dead Sea. In Deuteronomy, it can also refer to the lower Jordan Valley (see 1:1; 3:17).

Deuteronomy 5:1

statutes and ordinances: These technical terms describe the specific commands of the covenant. These are the rules Israel was required to obey.

In the covenant, the Lord was the greater partner, and Israel was the lesser partner. Israel showed loyalty to the Lord by obeying these commands.

Deuteronomy 5:1–32

The rest of the covenant laws explain and apply the Ten Commandments (5:6–21). These laws are based on those commandments.

Moses first gave the Ten Commandments to the people of Israel almost 40 years earlier at Mount Sinai (Exodus 20:2–17). Now he reminds the people of these commands before they enter the promised land.

Deuteronomy 5:1–26.19

This section contains the main part of the covenant document. It explains the stipulations, or required commands. These commands show how Israel was to live as God's covenant people.

The first part (5:1–11:32) presents the major stipulations. These focus especially on the first two commandments (5:7–10). These commandments teach Israel to worship the Lord alone and to avoid idols.

The rest of the section contains more specific instructions. These minor stipulations explain in detail how the major commandments should guide daily life.

Deuteronomy 5:9

- The children of sinful parents are not punished for the wrongdoings of their mothers and fathers, but the sins of any generation have consequences that last for generations (see 2 Samuel 12:10).
- Here, the word hate does not mean having bitter or hostile feelings. Instead, it means to turn away from or abandon a relationship.

Deuteronomy 5:10

those who love me: Those who choose to accept the Lord do not hate or reject him.

Deuteronomy 5:11

take the name of the LORD your God in vain: This means to use God's name in a wrong way. This can

mean using God's name to control or deceive others for personal gain. It can also mean using God's name carelessly. It may also mean making a promise in God's name to support something that is not true.

Deuteronomy 5:12

keeping it holy: Certain holy days were special and had great importance. On the Sabbath day, the community stopped working to worship the Lord (see 1 Corinthians 16:2; Hebrews 10:25).

Deuteronomy 5:15

This is why: God commanded Israel to observe a day of rest to remember that God stopped creating on the seventh day (Exodus 20:11). In Deuteronomy, the Sabbath also celebrated Israel's release from slavery in Egypt.

In the Christian tradition, the first day rather than the seventh is generally set apart to observe the resurrection of Jesus Christ. This is the most important event in Christian history (see study note on Revelation 1:10).

Deuteronomy 5:16

Honor: Parents represent God's authority, so children must obey and greatly respect them (compare Ephesians 6:1–3).

Deuteronomy 5:16–20

Jesus mentioned these five commands when asked, "What good thing must I do to obtain eternal life?" (Matthew 19:17–19; Mark 10:19; Luke 18:20).

Deuteronomy 5:17

murder: The Hebrew word can mean either "kill" or "murder." The law allowed killing in war and as punishment for certain serious crimes. So in this command, the word refers to the planned killing of an innocent person. See Matthew 5:21–22.

Deuteronomy 5:18

adultery: Jesus spoke about adultery in Matthew 5:27–28.

Deuteronomy 5:21

covet: This commandment is different because it addresses a desire, not an action. An evil desire is as offensive to God as an evil deed (see Matthew 5:27–28).

Deuteronomy 5:33

walk in all the ways: This phrase compares life to a journey. God called Israel to live in a way that kept the nation focused on its chosen and equipped purposes.

Deuteronomy 6:1

Moses added commands to decrees and regulations. This was the usual pattern for covenant stipulations (the laws in a covenant agreement; see 4:1; 5:1). The term commandments is a general term that refers to the whole body of instruction.

Deuteronomy 6:1–25

Moses here explains how the stipulations in the following sections should be applied and handed on to future generations.

Deuteronomy 6:2

God's great power and glory (see 4:10) mean that his people must fear him. To fear God means to treat him with deep respect and reverence (see also study notes on 7:21; 10:12–13).

Deuteronomy 6:3

The milk and honey in Canaan represented agriculture and grazing land. Compared to the desert food, Canaan's food was truly luxurious (see Exodus 3:8, 17).

Deuteronomy 6:4

The LORD our God, the LORD is One: Only God is worthy of worship (5:7).

Deuteronomy 6:4–5

Hear (Hebrew shema): The Shema is the basic statement of Israel's faith. It begins with the call to listen and obey God.

Jesus said that these verses contain the greatest commandment (Matthew 22:34–39; Mark 12:28–31; Luke 10:25–28). Jewish teachers in ancient times and today also honor these words. The rabbi Hillel, who lived in the first century BC, called the Shema the central teaching of the Hebrew Bible (the Old Testament). He said that the rest of the Scripture is commentary, meaning explanation of that main idea.

Deuteronomy 6:5

- love the LORD: See study note on Joshua 23:11.
- The words heart ... soul ... strength represent the mind, will, emotions, spirituality, and physical being. In other words, they refer to all that a person is and can do for God. This commandment is central to

God's covenant with Israel (see Matthew 22:37; Mark 12:30; Luke 10:27).

Deuteronomy 6:7

teach them diligently: The Hebrew verb shanan might describe carving words into a hard surface so they cannot be erased. It can also simply mean "repeat."

In either case, parents were to teach the Shema to their children again and again. They were to repeat it so often that it would be deeply fixed in their hearts and never forgotten.

Deuteronomy 6:8

- Tie them: The Lord's commandments (6:6)were to become part of daily life. They were to shape the thoughts and actions of parents and children, as if they were tied to their bodies.

Later in Jewish practice, some people took this phrase literally. They wrapped leather straps around their forearm and placed small boxes with words from the Torah inside them (see study note on 4:44).

- bind them: This phrase was also understood literally in later Judaism. People wore a small box that contained short passages from the Torah. These were called tefillin (Hebrew) or phylacteries (Greek).

These objects reminded people to teach and obey God's covenant (compare 11:18; Matthew 23:5).

Deuteronomy 6:9

Write them on the doorposts: In later Jewish practice, people placed short passages from Deuteronomy inside a small case called a mezuzah. They attached this case to the doorframes of their homes and other buildings.

It became a custom to touch the mezuzah when entering or leaving the house. This act showed respect for Scripture and trust in God's word.

Deuteronomy 6:13

Jesus quoted this verse when tempted by Satan (Matthew 4:10; Luke 4:8).

Deuteronomy 6:16

When Israel traveled through the Sinai desert after the exodus, they reached Rephidim. There was no water here (Exodus 17:1–7). Moses saw the people's demand for water as testing the Lord, so he called the place Massah, which means "testing."

Jesus later quoted this verse when Satan tempted him (Matthew 4:7; Luke 4:12).

Deuteronomy 6:21

The phrase a mighty hand is an anthropomorphism. An anthropomorphism is a way of speaking about God as if he had human features or actions (see study note on 8:2).

Deuteronomy 6:22

The signs and wonders refer to the ten plagues God sent to show his power to Israel and Egypt during the exodus (Exodus 7–12; see also Exodus 3:20; 4:5; Joshua 4:23–24).

Deuteronomy 6:25

if we are careful to observe ... as He has commanded us ... that will be our righteousness: Obedience shows that a person is already righteous, a status before God that comes from faith (see 24:13; Habakkuk 2:4; Romans 1:17; 4:1–5; Galatians 3:6–7; see also Genesis 15:6; Ephesians 2:8–9). When other nations saw Israel's commitment to obey the covenant, they could see that Israel was righteous.

Deuteronomy 7:1

- The Hittites were from Anatolia, which is now north-central Turkey. They set up colonies in distant places like Syria and were also linked to Canaan in the list of ancient nations (see Genesis 10:15; 23:3–20). The Hittite empire ended suddenly around 1200 BC. But people called Hittites still lived in Israel, such as "Uriah the Hittite" (2 Samuel 11:3; 23:39).

It is impossible to prove that the Hittites of Anatolia were the same as those mentioned in the Old Testament, but they were probably similar in some ways.

- Girgashites were an otherwise unknown Canaanite group (Genesis 10:16–17).
- For Amorites, see study note on Deuteronomy 1:4.
- The Canaanites were the original people of Canaan, living there since 3000 BC. They descended from Noah's son Ham (see Genesis 9:18–27).
- The Perizzites are not in the Table of Nations (Genesis 10:16–17), so they might not have any connection to the Canaanites.
- Many scholars think the Hivites were the same as the Horites (or Hurrians; see study note on Deuteronomy 2:1). They were a non-Semitic group found throughout the ancient Near East.
- The Jebusites had a connection to Jerusalem (Judges 1:21; 2 Samuel 5:6–8). King David bought land from Araunah the Jebusite to build an altar (2 Samuel 24:15–25). This site was where Solomon later built his temple (2 Chronicles 3:1).

Deuteronomy 7:1–26

Before Israel could occupy the promised land, they had to remove the people already living there (compare Genesis 13:14–17; 15:18–21). The land belonged to the Lord, and only God could decide who should live there.

Deuteronomy 7:5

- Engraved stone pillars called stelae usually represented pagan male gods. People commonly found these sacred pillars at shrines dedicated to Baal.
- Asherah poles, usually made of wood, represented Canaanite fertility goddesses, especially Asherah, the mother of the gods. These shrines might have developed as stylized sacred trees associated with fertility (see study note on 12:2).

Deuteronomy 7:6

Out of all the peoples on the earth, God chose Israel to be his prized possession. This means they belonged to him in a special way and were precious to him.

Israel did not earn this choice by doing anything special. Instead, God chose them because of his grace. Grace means God's kindness that is not earned and is freely given.

Deuteronomy 7:9

- The faithful God is completely reliable and trustworthy. God commended Abraham as righteous because he trusted in God and relied entirely on God's faithfulness (Genesis 15:6).
- In contrast to humans, who often fail to keep promises, the Lord faithfully keeps his covenant.

Deuteronomy 7:12

swore: In a covenant or treaty, the parties involved had to swear to follow its terms for it to be valid. God's promises are always certain because of his character (7:9; 32:4; Hebrews 6:18; James 1:17). He fulfilled the requirements of the covenant with Israel by swearing to keep its terms (see Genesis 22:16).

Deuteronomy 7:15

terrible diseases ... in Egypt: These might be the same as the plagues, such as those mentioned in Exodus 9:9. They may also include other serious diseases that commonly affected the Egyptians.

Deuteronomy 7:19

- The phrase signs and wonders refers to the miraculous acts God did to make his enemies afraid and to inspire awe and praise among his people (see 6:22).
- mighty hand and outstretched arm: See study notes on 4:34 and 8:2.

Deuteronomy 7:20

the hornet: Whether God sent stinging insects or another source of fear, he would expel the remaining Canaanites from the land (Exodus 23:28; Joshua 24:12).

Deuteronomy 7:21

awesome (literally one to be feared): This kind of fear does not mean terror, as if God were cruel or unfair.

Instead, it refers to reverential fear. This means deep respect and awe before a loving God. His greatness and majesty are so powerful that they fill people with wonder and holy fear.

Deuteronomy 7:24

wipe out their names: In the ancient world, a person's name represented that person's ongoing life through future generations. A name continued through children and grandchildren.

So to erase a name meant more than killing one person. It meant ending a family line and removing its future. When God destroyed a nation in his war of judgment, that nation lost its descendants and its lasting identity.

Deuteronomy 7:25–26

it is detestable to the LORD your God: Pagan worship denies God's uniqueness and rejects his demand for exclusive worship (5:7–9). The terrible and disgusting ceremonies often linked to pagan worship opposed God's holy nature. But Israel risked adopting similar beliefs and practices (12:31; 13:12–17).

An Israelite who recognized or worshiped false gods committed treason against the Lord. In other words, that person was unfaithful to God as king. The only solution was the complete destruction of these detestable objects.

Deuteronomy 7:26

set apart for destruction (Hebrew kherem): See study note on 2:34.

Deuteronomy 8:1–20

After Israel settled in the land, they might begin to think that their success came from their own strength and skill. This is a common human tendency.

Moses warned them not to become proud or congratulate themselves. They must remember that God alone

gives prosperity and success. All that they achieve comes from him.

Deuteronomy 8:2

- to know what was in your heart: God already knew the deepest thoughts of the Israelites (Psalms 51:6; 139:1, 4, 23). He did not need to learn new information. Instead, he wanted their true character to be shown by their actions.
- in order to know ... whether or not: The Old Testament often describes God in human ways. This is called anthropomorphism (speaking about God as if he has human qualities) and anthropopathism (speaking about God as if he has human emotions). These ways of speaking help people understand God better.

However, God is not limited like humans. He is not limited in knowledge, power, or greatness. In this verse, God is described as if he needed to learn the future. But other passages teach that God knows everything. God knows the past, present, and future (Psalm 139:1–18; Hebrews 4:13).

Deuteronomy 8:3

- The word manna comes from the Hebrew words man hu, which mean "What is it?" God provided this food in a miraculous way to teach his people to depend fully on him (Exodus 16:1–30; Numbers 11:4–9).

Manna represented the word of God. God's word is even more important for life and well-being than food.

- man does not live on bread alone: Jesus quoted these words when Satan tempted him (Matthew 4:4; Luke 4:4). Jesus used this Scripture to answer Satan and show that people need God's word more than physical food.

Deuteronomy 8:9

Iron was not widely used during this part of the Bronze Age. Only a few cultures knew how to smelt iron (heat the ore to remove metal) and shape it into tools and weapons (see 1 Samuel 13:19–21).

Later, Israel learned to use this much stronger metal. They were able to mine it and make tools and weapons from it (see Joshua 17:16–18; 1 Kings 6:7; 2 Kings 6:5; 1 Chronicles 22:3).

Deuteronomy 8:15

water from the rock: See Exodus 17:6; Numbers 20:2–13; see also Deuteronomy 1:37.

Deuteronomy 8:18

- This covenant was not the one God made with the Israelites at Sinai. It was the one he first made with Abraham, then with Isaac and Jacob (Genesis 15:1–21; 17:1–21; Genesis 26:1–5; Genesis 28:1–4, 13–15; 46:1–4).
- For a covenant to be legal and proper, all parties had to swear an oath. Although God, by his nature, could never break a promise, he followed this custom (see Deuteronomy 7:12).

Deuteronomy 9:1

fortified to the heavens: This phrase shows that humans cannot break through these walls by themselves (Numbers 13:28). For Israel to succeed, God must guide them and fight for them (Deuteronomy 9:5).

Deuteronomy 9:3

The image of a consuming fire shows God fighting his enemies (see 1:30). God will not only use fire. He will be an unstoppable fire, consuming everything in his path. In the end, Israel will only need to walk in and occupy the conquered land.

Deuteronomy 9:5

to keep the promise: In the covenant promises made to the patriarchs, God swore that their descendants would inherit the land of Canaan (Genesis 13:14–17; 15:18–21; see Deuteronomy 1:8; 8:18).

Deuteronomy 9:6

stiff-necked: This describes a work animal that refuses to bend its neck to accept a yoke (a wooden bar placed on animals to guide and control them; Exodus 32:9; 33:3, 5; Isaiah 48:4). The word describes someone who refuses to obey or change direction. Sadly, Israel was not stubborn only at certain times. Stubbornness became the nation's usual attitude and way of acting.

Deuteronomy 9:9

- the covenant: Here, this refers to the promises God made with Israel about 40 years earlier at Sinai (see 4:13).
- In the Bible, the phrase forty days and forty nights often means a time of trial or testing (Exodus 34:28). The fast of Moses was like the fast of Jesus (Matthew 4:2).

While it is possible to go without food for forty days, a person usually cannot live without water for more than a few days. God directly sustained Moses (compare Matthew 4:11).

Deuteronomy 9:10

Referring to the finger of God emphasizes God's personal interest and involvement in communicating the text of the covenant (see study notes on 4:34 and 8:2; see also Exodus 31:18; 32:15–16; 34:1, 28).

Deuteronomy 9:12

The type of idol mentioned here comes from a Hebrew word meaning "cast" or "pour." They would make it by pouring liquid metal into a mold (Exodus 32:1–4).

People made other idols from carved wood, stone, clay, or precious metals hammered into thin sheets over wooden cores.

Deuteronomy 9:14

blot out their name: The Lord threatened to destroy Israel's identity and existence (see study note on 7:24).

Deuteronomy 9:16

When Israel was at Mount Sinai, the people made a golden calf as an idol (Exodus 32). This idol was likely shaped like the sacred bulls and cows that people worshiped in Egypt. Two well-known Egyptian gods were Apis, a bull god, and Hathor, a cow goddess. Both were connected with fertility (the ability to have children, animals, and good crops).

Later, when the Israelites entered the land of Canaan, they met people who worshiped other fertility gods. These Canaanite religions taught that their gods gave rain, crops, and children. The Israelites would be tempted to trust these false gods instead of trusting the one true God to bless them (compare Deuteronomy 8:18–20).

Deuteronomy 9:22

- Soon after Israel left Mount Sinai, the people began to complain against the Lord. They complained again and again with anger. As a result, the Lord sent a fire that killed some of them. The name Taberah means "place of burning."
- Earlier, the people came to a place called Massah. There, they tested the Lord. They questioned whether he could provide water for them. The name Massah means "place of testing."
- At Kibroth-hattaavah, the Israelites demanded food other than manna. The Lord provided quail in a miraculous way. The people ate too much and showed greedy desire. Because of this sin, many of them died. The name Kibroth-hattaavah means "graves of gluttony."

Deuteronomy 9:23

Israel used Kadesh-barnea as its main camp during the 38 years of wandering in the wilderness (see also study note on 1:19).

Deuteronomy 9:26

The Lord redeemed Israel from their bondage in Egypt by his own gracious efforts on their behalf.

Deuteronomy 9:27

In Hebrew, the term translated as remember does not always mean "to recall something forgotten," especially when God is the one remembering (see study notes on 8:2 and 32:36). Here, it means that God would keep his promises to the patriarchs by doing what he said.

Asking God to remember is more than making him aware of a need. It is a plea for him to act and meet that need (compare Luke 23:42–43).

Deuteronomy 10:1

The ark was a gold-plated wooden chest that held the stone tablets. It was kept in the Most Holy Place in the tabernacle or temple (Exodus 25:10).

Later, they also placed a pot of manna and Aaron's flowering rod in the ark (Hebrews 9:4). The ark was the throne where the invisible Lord sat on earth among his people (see study notes on Exodus 25:22 and Leviticus 16:2).

Deuteronomy 10:3

acacia wood: This strong desert tree is likely the species Acacia raddiana. This is the only type of acacia in the Negev that grows large enough to provide building timber.

Deuteronomy 10:5

there they have remained: Sometimes, phrases like this in Deuteronomy show that the book was edited after Moses first wrote it.

When these final edits were made, the stone tablets were still kept in the ark of the covenant.

Deuteronomy 10:12–13

fear the LORD your God: This fear is not terror from fearing his anger. Instead, God wanted his people to understand their limits and how unworthy they were to be in his divine presence (see study notes on 7:21 and Proverbs 1:7).

Deuteronomy 10:16

circumcise your hearts: This is a figure of speech. It uses the language of circumcision to describe an inner change.

Circumcision was the physical sign of the covenant that God gave to Abraham (Genesis 17:9–14). Here, however, the command points to a deeper meaning. The people must remove stubbornness and sin from their hearts.

This image includes both inward change and outward obedience to the covenant (Romans 2:28–29).

Deuteronomy 10:17

- The phrase God of gods does not mean that other gods actually exist. It shows God's complete sovereignty over all powers in heaven and earth. The Hebrew word 'elohim, translated as "gods," can also refer to angels or other powerful beings (see Psalm 82:1).
- showing no partiality: people with power and influence do not impress God. So he does not give them special treatment (see Deuteronomy 1:17).

Deuteronomy 10:18

foreigner (literally sojourner): A group of non-Israelites described as a "mixed multitude" left Egypt with the Israelites (Exodus 12:38). Later, other foreigners settled in Israel for different reasons.

Some of these foreigners did not intend to join Israel as a covenant people. Others, though not full citizens, respected God or were potential converts. They did not have the same rights as Israelites and were sometimes treated unfairly or neglected.

Deuteronomy 11:4

The common translation Red Sea (literally sea of reeds) comes from the Greek Old Testament. People called it the "Sea of Reeds" because marshy plants grew along its shores.

Deuteronomy 11:6

Dathan and Abiram: See Numbers 16:1–40. In the government of God's kingdom, God set up levels of authority and command against which people could not rebel. God chose Moses and Aaron as leaders. So, when Dathan and Abiram rebelled against Moses, they also rebelled against God's sovereign rule.

Deuteronomy 11:8–32

Here, Moses adds to the covenant stipulations (the commands in chapters 5–11) a list of blessings and curses. These blessings and curses are similar to the longer list that appears at the end of the covenant text in 27–28. They show the results of obeying or disobeying the covenant.

Deuteronomy 11:12

a land for which the LORD your God cares: God's care included blessing the land with all the resources his people would need to survive and prosper there.

Deuteronomy 11:24

where your foot treads: This idea suggests claiming a territory by placing a foot on it or walking through it (see Genesis 13:17; Joshua 1:3; 14:9).

Deuteronomy 11:26

In covenant contexts, a blessing is the outcome of obedience, while a curse is the result of disobedience (see chapters 27–28).

Deuteronomy 11:29

- Mount Gerizim is a well-known hill located just west of Shechem. Later, the Samaritans built a temple there (see John 4:20).
- Mount Ebal is on the opposite side of the valley from Mount Gerizim, to the east of Shechem.

Deuteronomy 11:30

- Gilgal was the first camp the Israelites made in Canaan after crossing the Jordan River (Joshua 4:19). It was about 3.2 kilometers (two miles) northeast of Jericho, but its exact location is uncertain. A line from Jericho to Shechem would pass near Gilgal.
- The Oak of Moreh was near Shechem. This was where Abram set up his first camp in Canaan (Genesis 12:6). Jacob later buried Laban's idols there (Genesis 35:4).

Deuteronomy 12:1–26.15

After Moses explained the principles of the covenant, he explained how to apply them in daily life (5:1–11:32). This section expands on the Ten Commandments and addresses issues that happen in complex human relationships.

Deuteronomy 12:2

green tree: The Canaanites used groups of trees as places for worship. They chose these trees because their green leaves showed fertility and life.

Sometimes the trees were made into wooden poles set in the ground. These poles were used to honor the mother goddess, Asherah (see 7:5).

Deuteronomy 12:3

- sacred pillars: See study note on 7:5.
- Asherah poles: They dedicated these wooden poles to the mother goddess, Asherah. They were the feminine counterpart to the sacred pillar.
- wipe out their names: Destroying all idols and traces of pagan worship would lead to the names of these gods being forgotten. Future generations would not know about them (see also study note on 7:24).

Deuteronomy 12:5

establish as a dwelling for His Name: The name of God represents the God himself. God lived among his people in a particular place by placing his name there (see Exodus 3:13–14).

Deuteronomy 12:6

All of the offerings listed here show thanksgiving, fellowship, and loyalty to the Lord.

In a covenant relationship, a vassal (a subject or servant) gave tribute to a great king. This was a way to show submission and to promise faithfulness (see study note on 1:31).

Deuteronomy 12:8

does what seems right in his own eyes: Until the exodus, the Israelites probably worshiped at many shrines in Egypt. With the construction of the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle), worship became centralized. It stayed that way with the later building of the temple.

In the future, the community would need to gather on specific occasions to worship the Lord together at the central holy place. But local worship by individuals, families, and even villages would continue (see Exodus 20:24–26; 1 Samuel 9:11–14).

Deuteronomy 12:12

The Levites were descendants of Jacob's son Levi. God set them apart to serve him full-time in Israel's religious life (Numbers 18:1–7). Their main job was to help the priests with their duties.

Since the priests and Levites could not work in regular jobs, they relied on the generosity of Israel's other tribes for their support (Numbers 18:21–24).

Deuteronomy 12:15

- whenever you want, you may slaughter and eat meat: This means animals for eating, not for ceremonial sacrifice.
- ceremonially clean and unclean: They could slaughter animals for food without purification ceremonies needed for sacrificial animals.

Deuteronomy 12:16

The rule against eating blood applied to both sacrificial animals and those killed for food. Blood represented life, so it was holy and belonged only to God. This principle existed from the beginning of creation and came before the law was given (Genesis 4:10–11; 9:4–6; Leviticus 17:11). See also study note on Leviticus 7:26–27.

Deuteronomy 12:18

God will choose: This refers to the central sanctuary (main place of worship). At first, this was the tabernacle. Later, it was the temple in Jerusalem.

Deuteronomy 12:21

you may slaughter: Because an animal's blood was considered holy (see Genesis 9:4–6), meat for eating had to be slaughtered at the central place of worship whenever possible (compare Leviticus 17:8–9).

If it was not possible to go to the central location, the animal could be sacrificed locally. Even then, the blood had to be handled and disposed of in a way that followed God's instructions (Deuteronomy 12:23–25; compare Leviticus 17:10–12).

Deuteronomy 12:23

the blood is the life: This figure of speech equates the means (blood) with the effect (life). Since life is holy, blood, as the way life moves throughout a body, is also holy (see also Leviticus 17:11).

Deuteronomy 12:27

you may eat the meat: The exception was meat used in burnt offerings, which was for the Lord. These offerings were completely burned in the fire (see Leviticus 1:3–17 and study note).

Deuteronomy 12:31

burn their sons and daughters: Human sacrifice was a terrible practice in ancient pagan religions. The Ammonites believed that their god Molech demanded this sacrifice from his followers (Leviticus 18:21; 20:2; 2 Kings 23:10; Jeremiah 32:35).

Deuteronomy 13:1

God performed signs and miracles to inspire wonder and faith in those who saw them (see 6:22). False prophets and magicians could imitate these acts to some extent, sometimes misleading God's people (see Exodus 7:11, 22; 8:7).

Deuteronomy 13:1–18

Prophets who tried to lead Israel away from the one true God committed treason, which was punishable by death. No other religion demanded exclusive worship of their national gods. As a result, such severe penalties for worshiping other gods were unknown in the ancient Near East.

Deuteronomy 13:5

- dreamer: Literally dreamer of dreams. It refers to someone who claims to receive messages through dreams.
- purge (literally you must burn): God commanded that false prophets be removed completely so that their harmful influence would not remain. See also 17:12; 19:13.

Deuteronomy 13:6

The Israelites had heard about these false gods before. However, they had not worshiped them.

If they began to worship them, they would break the first two commandments. These commandments express the main meaning of the covenant.

Deuteronomy 13:9

Your hand must be the first against him: Because the guilty person could be someone from your own family, this command was very difficult. It tested how deeply a person was committed to worship the Lord alone (13:6).

God required his people to love and obey him above all else. Their love for God had to come before their love for family members and friends (Matthew 10:34–39).

Deuteronomy 13:13

wicked men (literally sons of Belial): In Hebrew, the phrase son or sons of often shows that a person belongs to a group or shares certain qualities. So sons of Belial refers to people who share evil or worthless behavior.

Wicked men were people who deceived others and led them away from what is right (Proverbs 6:12; 16:27; 19:28; Nahum 1:11).

Deuteronomy 13:14

An abomination is any action or even thought that is offensive to God (see study notes on 7:25–26; 12:31).

Deuteronomy 13:16

Plunder or "spoils of war" were not to be kept. God had ordered them to be completely destroyed (see 2:34; Leviticus 27:28–29).

Deuteronomy 14:1

- cut yourselves: This pagan custom often linked to mourning ceremonies, possibly to try to get the dead to return to life (see 1 Kings 18:28; Zechariah 13:4–6).
- shave your foreheads: This practice also related to mourning for the dead (see Leviticus 19:27–28; 21:5–6). But the exact meaning of this ceremony is unclear.

Deuteronomy 14:1–21

See "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note.

Deuteronomy 14:2

The basic Hebrew meaning of holy is the separation of a person or thing for a specific purpose. It can also mean "pure" or "morally and spiritually good."

Deuteronomy 14:6

split hoof ... chews the cud: These animals listed in in 14:4–5 could be eaten, unlike those in 14:7–8. People gained health benefits from following these rules. But something was ceremonially clean or unclean only because God said so.

Deuteronomy 14:7

The rock badger (or hyrax) is a small mammal about the size of a rabbit. It has short toes with flat nails that look like small hooves, and it has soft pads on its feet that help it climb rocks.

Deuteronomy 14:8

The instruction to avoid touching their dead bodies was mainly to maintain ceremonial purity.

Deuteronomy 14:11–18

These animals are grouped as flying animals that eat rotting flesh.

Deuteronomy 14:19–20

flying insects: Compare Leviticus 11:20–23.

Deuteronomy 14:21

- God considered animals that died naturally to be ceremonially unclean. This was true even if they were ceremonially clean when alive. This was because they did not slaughter them according to ceremonial rules. They did not properly drain their blood and dispose of it (see 12:23–25).
- You must not cook a young goat in its mother's milk: This pagan practice was improper because it showed insensitivity to the natural bond between mothers and their offspring (see 28:56–57).

Deuteronomy 14:22–27

set aside a tenth: A tithe (or tenth) is the practice of giving one-tenth of income or produce. People gave a tenth long before the law of Moses (Genesis 14:20; 28:22). Other ancient cultures also practiced this.

In the Bible, the tithe is treated as a tax or tribute. It is collected by the Lord from his people, who are like his subjects. The Lord, as sovereign, claims this portion as holy (see study notes on Deuteronomy 1:31 and 12:6).

Deuteronomy 14:23

the place He will choose as a dwelling for His Name: This is the central sanctuary. This place is the Lord's special dwelling on the earth among his people. It is where God is present with them (see 12:5, 18).

Deuteronomy 14:26

People used wine and other alcoholic drinks in worship ceremonies and celebrations (Genesis 14:18; 35:14; Exodus 29:40–41; Matthew 26:27). These drinks represented God's blessing (Genesis 27:25, 28; 49:11; 1 Chronicles 12:40; Psalm 104:15; Song of Solomon 4:10; 5:1; Isaiah 25:6; Matthew 26:29).

Deuteronomy 14:27

The Levites did not receive land of their own. They were also not allowed to do regular work for money.

Because of this, they depended on the other Israelite tribes for support (see 12:12).

Deuteronomy 14:28

All adult Israelite men had to give a tithe (a tenth) every year. This was part of their festival celebrations (15:20; 16:16–17). Every third year, the tithe supported the Levites and other dependent groups in Israelite society (14:29). See study note on Leviticus 27:30.

Deuteronomy 15:1

cancel debts: This refers to releasing people from what they owe. It means freeing them from financial bondage (being trapped by unpaid debt).

The creditor was to forgive the debt. The person who owed money would not face further penalty for failing to repay it.

Deuteronomy 15:1–23

The law of Moses included rules about borrowing and lending. Here, God commanded Israel to cancel debts in the seventh year and to lend generously to the poor.

These laws helped poor people survive times of need. They also placed limits on the wealthy so they would not take advantage of those who were vulnerable.

Deuteronomy 15:2

The remission happened every seventh year across the nation ("the Sabbath year," Leviticus 25:1–7). The timing followed the national calendar, not the date when a loan was made. As a result, a loan could be canceled only one year after it was given.

Deuteronomy 15:4

If Israel had obeyed the covenant fully, there would have been no poor people in the nation.

However, this ideal situation never became reality in ancient Israel. Poverty remained a serious problem among the people.

Deuteronomy 15:6

you will lend to many nations: If Israel obeyed God, the nation would become prosperous (having great wealth and resources). It would be able to lend to other nations instead of borrowing from them.

This prosperity would show that God was keeping his promise to Abraham. God had promised that Abraham's descendants would be a blessing to all nations (Genesis 12:2–3; 17:4–6; 26:3–4).

Deuteronomy 15:11

The fact that some people will always be poor in an imperfect world is not an excuse to ignore their

struggles. Instead, it emphasizes the need for wealthy individuals to help improve the lives of the poor (Matthew 26:6–13).

Deuteronomy 15:12

If a fellow Hebrew, a man or a woman, is sold to you and serves you: This arrangement allowed a person who owed money to work and repay the debt. In this way, the debtor could meet financial obligations to the creditor.

The service could last no more than seven years (but see 15:16–17 for exceptions).

Deuteronomy 15:16

he loves you: In the setting of a covenant, this phrase describes a committed relationship.

This relationship includes both faithfulness to promises and deep personal care.

Deuteronomy 15:17

pierce it through his ear: Piercing the servant's ear was a public sign. It showed that the bondservant had chosen to serve his master for life.

This mark identified him as permanently belonging to that household. Some believe this background may help explain Paul's words, "I bear on my body the marks of Jesus" (Galatians 6:17).

Deuteronomy 15:18

worth twice the wages: A bondservant worked every day and did not serve for limited hours. Because of this, his work was worth more than the work of a hired laborer.

A hired worker served only for certain hours of the day. The bondservant's full-time service made his value greater.

Deuteronomy 15:19

The firstborn males of livestock represented the firstborn sons of Israel who had been spared from death in the tenth plague (Exodus 12:12, 29; 13:2, 12; 22:29).

Deuteronomy 15:21

A defect was any physical flaw that lowered the value of an animal.

If an animal was already of little or no value, offering it would not be a true sacrifice. A sacrifice required giving something valuable (2 Samuel 24:24).

Deuteronomy 15:23

The blood of an animal was understood to represent its life. Life was considered sacred because it comes from God.

For this reason, it was wrong to eat the blood (see 12:16).

Deuteronomy 16:1–8

- The Passover (Hebrew pesakh) is the feast celebrating God's deliverance of Israel from the tenth plague and from slavery in Egypt (see Exodus 11–12; Leviticus 23:5–8).
- The exodus was so important in Israel's history that the month of Abib, when it happened, became the start of Israel's yearly calendar (see Exodus 12:2).

Deuteronomy 16:2

a dwelling for His Name: The Lord's name represented the Lord himself. When God placed his name in the tabernacle or temple, he was effectively taking up residence there (see 12:5, 18).

Deuteronomy 16:3

Yeast (or leaven) often symbolizes corruption or sin (Leviticus 6:14–17; Matthew 16:11–12). At the first Passover, the Israelites did not use yeast because they had no time to let bread rise (see Exodus 12:10–14). Each part of the yearly Passover celebration reminded the Israelites of what God had done for them.

Deuteronomy 16:10

The Feast of Weeks happened seven weeks after Passover to celebrate the wheat harvest (Exodus 34:22; Leviticus 23:15–22).

Deuteronomy 16:13–17

The Feast of Tabernacles is called this because God told the Israelites to live for one week in simple shelters made from tree branches. These shelters reminded them of the years they wandered in the wilderness (Leviticus 23:33–43). This feast also celebrated the fall harvest.

Deuteronomy 16:16

Participation in the festival was required of every man, but women and children could participate as well (16:11, 14; compare Luke 2:41).

Deuteronomy 16:18

- judges and officials: The use of both words together may mean that they had similar roles. The word

officials usually refers to public leaders in general. Here, however, it likely refers to people who helped carry out the law. They may have served as administrators of justice or as officers who enforced the law.
- with righteous judgment: This phrase means judging by a clear and just standard. Decisions were to be based on what was right. They were not to be changed because of pressure from the public or from private interests.

Deuteronomy 16:18–17.13

The community of Israel, like any nation, needed different kinds of leaders. These leaders helped keep the people united and guided them in the right direction.

The Lord told Moses to set up a proper system of leadership. He also gave clear standards for choosing leaders and explained the duties of each role.

Deuteronomy 16:19

show partiality: See study note on 1:16–17.

Deuteronomy 16:21–22

Asherah pole ... sacred pillar: See study note on 7:5; also see 12:3; Isaiah 27:8–9; Micah 5:13–15.

Deuteronomy 17:1

defect or serious flaw: A sick or defective animal was worth very little money. Because of this, offering such an animal to the Lord was not a true sacrifice (compare 15:21).

Deuteronomy 17:3

The forces of heaven include visible things such as the sun, moon, and stars. They also include unseen beings such as angels.

Worshiping anything that God created is a clear violation of the second commandment (see 5:9).

Deuteronomy 17:4

Anything that offends the Lord could be called an abomination (see 7:25; 12:31; 13:14). This word describes actions that are deeply hateful or detestable in God's sight.

Deuteronomy 17:5

your gates: A typical town in ancient Israel was small, 4 hectares (about 10 acres) or less, and crowded. Most towns had few open areas.

One open space was an area just inside or outside the main gate. People used this area for public gatherings, including trials and other judicial events.

In this passage, the place is clearly outside the town. Stoning to death did not happen inside the walls (22:24; 1 Kings 21:10; see Deuteronomy 22:21).

Deuteronomy 17:7

- The rule for witnesses to throw the first stones prevented false accusations. Giving false testimony had serious consequences. Requiring a witness to lead an execution ensured his testimony was reliable. He would feel guilty if he killed an innocent person (see John 8:1–11).
- The people would remove evil from among them by executing those whose sins brought guilt to the community of Israel (see "Purge the Evil" Theme Note; compare 1 Corinthians 5:12–13 and study note).

Deuteronomy 17:8

whether the controversy within your gates is regarding bloodshed: In the Old Testament, as in many legal systems today, murder was intentional, and manslaughter was accidental (compare 19:1–13).

Deuteronomy 17:9

priests and to the judge: Both kinds of leaders could decide cases. These cases could be about religious matters or about everyday civil matters.

Deuteronomy 17:11

Do not turn aside: This Hebrew phrase means staying on a straight path (see Proverbs 4:25–27; Hebrews 12:13). After giving a verdict, they must apply the sentence according to the law and evidence. They must follow a fair and righteous way that ensures justice.

Deuteronomy 17:12

purge the evil: The harmful effects of evil should not remain in the community. If they are allowed to continue, they will spread and damage others.

For this reason, evil had to be removed completely from among the people.

Deuteronomy 17:15

the king whom the LORD your God shall choose: Having a human king was not against God's plan for Israel (compare 1 Samuel 8:6–7). God had promised Abraham and Sarah that their descendants would include kings (Genesis 17:6, 16; see also Genesis 35:11).

However, the misuse of kingship was condemned.

The Bible also teaches that the Messiah (God's chosen one) would have a kingly role (2 Samuel 7:11–15; Psalms 2; 110; Isaiah 9:6–7). This shows that God's plan includes both human and divine royalty.

Deuteronomy 17:16

You are never to go back that way again: Going there would show that the king did not rely on God, who freed Israel from slavery in Egypt. The best horses came from Egypt (see 1 Kings 10:28–29).

Deuteronomy 17:17

- many wives: Here God does not ban or support polygamy (having more than one wife). This principle intends to control and manage the practice.

In ancient times, kings married many wives to form political alliances with other kingdoms. This showed they relied on human power instead of God's provision.
Kings David and Solomon ignored this warning, causing great harm to themselves and the nation (2 Samuel 5:13; 12:11; 1 Kings 11:3–4).

- must not accumulate: Gathering wealth was another indication that a king relied on human resources.

Deuteronomy 17:18

this instruction (Hebrew this torah): Here instruction refers to the book of Deuteronomy or possibly only this passage about having a king (monarchy) in Israel. For torah, see study note on 4:44.

Deuteronomy 18:1

The term Levitical priests refers to the whole tribe of Levi. All Levites served the Lord in some way.

However, in a strict sense, only the descendants of Aaron were priests. The other Levites were not priests. They served as assistants to the priests (see 12:12).

Deuteronomy 18:2

the LORD is their inheritance: The inheritance of the Levites was spiritual, not territorial or material. They possessed the Lord by giving their whole lives to his service. This idea is the remarkable reversal of the idea that the Lord possessed Israel (see 7:6).

Deuteronomy 18:3

In ancient Israel, people considered the shoulder, cheeks, and stomach of oxen and sheep as the best cuts of meat. They honored God's priests by giving them these best parts (see Leviticus 7:28–34).

Deuteronomy 18:8

received money from the sale of his father's estate: The Levites served full-time at the tabernacle and later at the temple. Even so, they could still own property, such as towns and pastureland (see Numbers 35:1–8).

The Levites were to receive support from the regular offerings that God set apart for them. They did not have to give up their own property in order to serve.

Deuteronomy 18:10

- Let no one be found among you who sacrifices his son or daughter in the fire: Some Canaanite religions practiced child sacrifice to please their gods. God strictly warned Israel against participating in this practice (Exodus 34:15–16; Leviticus 18:21; 20:2–5).

When they did, it brought God's judgment (2 Kings 17:16–17; 21:6; Ezekiel 23:37).

- divination: In the ancient Near East, diviners (people who tried to learn the future) were seen as experts at reading signs called omens (events believed to show what would happen next). One common method was extispicy (examining the internal organs of animals). They studied the liver, kidneys, and other organs of sacrificed animals to look for signs.
- conjury: Conjurers tried to call up the spirits of the dead. People believed these spirits could give secret knowledge or power.
- Diviners would use divining cups to interpret omens (see Genesis 44:5). They would place drops of oil in water, and the spread of the oil indicated a message to the diviner. This is similar to reading tea leaves.
- sorcery: This involved performing unusual acts or signs to mislead people (Exodus 7:11; Malachi 3:5).

Deuteronomy 18:11

- cast spells: These spoken formulas (special words believed to have power) were used to harm people. The person speaking the spell would call on a curse to destroy or injure someone. Balaam, a false prophet, was hired to do this against Israel (Numbers 22:2–6).
- medium or spiritist: These people claimed they could speak with the spirits of the dead. They were believed to be especially skilled at calling up and communicating with these spirits (see 1 Samuel 28:3–25).

Deuteronomy 18:15

a prophet like me: This would be extraordinary because Moses had no equal among the prophets (see 34:10–11). This prophet would come from among your brothers. Israel had to listen to him (18:19). The prophets of Old Testament Israel would partially fulfill the role of God's spokesmen. Israel had to obey them.

Later, Judaism anticipated this prophet as a key messianic figure (see John 1:21; 6:14; 7:40). The New Testament identifies Jesus as this prophet (Acts 3:18–26).

Deuteronomy 18:18

The prophet (18:15) would be the Lord's spokesman, as Moses was (see 4:10–17; Exodus 7:1).

Deuteronomy 18:19

To refuse to listen to the spokesman of the Lord is to refuse to listen to the Lord himself. God speaks through his chosen messengers.

Deuteronomy 18:22

Any prophet whose prediction does not come true must be identified as false, even if that person says he speaks for God.

A claim alone is not enough. If the message does not happen as promised, the prophet is not from God.

Deuteronomy 19:1–13

Cities of refuge were placed in different parts of the land (19:2). They were located carefully so people could reach them easily.

A person accused of killing someone could run to one of these cities for protection. There, the person would be safe until a fair trial took place (see 4:41; Numbers 35:6–29).

Deuteronomy 19:2

The three cities mentioned here were in Canaan, west of the Jordan River. Three other cities were located east of the Jordan in Transjordan (see Numbers 35:13–14; Joshua 20:7).

Deuteronomy 19:4

a manslayer ... having killed ... accidentally: This refers to a person who does not plan the act of killing someone in advance (see 17:8).

Deuteronomy 19:6

avenger of blood (literally the redeemer of blood): The law allowed a victim's family to avenge murder. They could execute the killer when they found him (Numbers 35:16–21).

The idea was that blood shed by the victim must be paid for by the blood of the person responsible for the act (see Genesis 4:15; 9:6). In this way, the land made unclean by the shed blood could be purified (Numbers 35:33–34).

Deuteronomy 19:9

If Israel had remained faithful to the covenant, God would have given them more land (19:8). They would have needed three more cities of refuge. Sadly, this never happened because Israel disobeyed the Lord.

Deuteronomy 19:11

The Hebrew word translated as a man hates indicates a long-lasting hateful attitude. This attitude could be used as evidence that the person was likely to commit a crime and probably did it.

Deuteronomy 19:13

You are to purge (literally burn): In this context, the land could only be made free from guilt in cases of murder if blood vengeance was carried out. This act would remove the impurity. See also 13:5; 17:12.

Deuteronomy 19:15

The testimony of one witness had no more authority than the word of the accused. But two or three witnesses could confirm or challenge each other's statements. For New Testament references to this law, see Matthew 18:15–20; John 8:17–18; 2 Corinthians 13:1–2 and study note.

Deuteronomy 19:21

The legal principle described as life for life is known as lex talionis ("law of retaliation"). This means the punishment must match the crime (see Exodus 21:23; Leviticus 24:20). It should not be too weak or too harsh.

Appropriate punishment is a necessary function of government (compare Romans 13:1–7). It helped maintain Israel's spiritual integrity as God's people (see study note on Deuteronomy 17:7).

But vengeance belongs to God, not individuals (see 1 Samuel 25:26, 33; Matthew 5:38–39; 1 Corinthians 6:1–8).

Deuteronomy 20:4

to fight for you: This promise shows that God starts wars, carries them out, and brings them to victory against his enemies.

The purpose of these wars was to remove enemies who refused to turn from evil and to protect his people from being corrupted (see 1:30).

Deuteronomy 20:7

another man marry her: In this situation, if a man died, he would not have children to carry on his name. Ancient Israel considered this to be a great tragedy.

Deuteronomy 20:10–15

The people living in the land of Canaan had already been placed under the ban (7:1–6). This means they were set apart for complete destruction as part of God's judgment.

So this command refers to other nations. It applies to people whom Israel would fight outside the land (20:15).

Deuteronomy 20:11

forced laborers: These were people who had to work against their will. This kind of labor was often required of prisoners of war. At times, even some Israelites were made to do this work (1 Kings 5:13–18; 9:15, 21; 12:18).

Deuteronomy 20:15

cities that are far away: These were outside the borders of the promised land.

Deuteronomy 20:19

You must not cut them down: In war, armies often cut down trees. They do this so their enemies cannot use the trees for food or wood.

However, this situation was different. The Israelites were not simply attacking and leaving. They were going to live in that land.

Because they would settle there, the trees would be useful to them. The trees could provide food, shade, and building materials in the future.

Deuteronomy 20:20

This equipment consisted of the materials built up against a city wall as part of the effort to bring it under siege.

Deuteronomy 21:1

In contrast to the word translated murder in the Ten Commandments (see study note on 5:17), the Hebrew verb here translated as slain (literally pierced through) shows clear evidence that the death was not from natural causes.

Deuteronomy 21:1–9

The guilt of murder was usually removed through the death of the murderer (19:11–13; Numbers 35:30–34). However, if the murderer was unknown, the guilt could still be removed by using this ritual.

Deuteronomy 21:3–8

A family member seeking revenge could not blame the entire community (19:6–7; Numbers 35:16–29).

Deuteronomy 21:4

The stream would be an ever-flowing brook. It would be located in an isolated area, away from people and animals. This would help keep it free from contaminants (anything that makes something unclean).

Deuteronomy 21:6

wash their hands: In the ancient world, people sometimes washed their hands to show they were innocent. This action showed that they were not guilty of wrongdoing (compare Matthew 27:24).

In this case, the community washed their hands to declare that they were not responsible for the crime. The crime had taken place near them, but they had not committed it.

Deuteronomy 21:12

Shaving her head and cutting her nails showed that the captive woman was leaving her home and family behind. These actions marked her separation from her past life.

By doing this, she prepared to join a new family and a new community. These actions symbolized that she was beginning a different stage of life.

Deuteronomy 21:13

Changing the clothes she was wearing showed that she was beginning a new life. It also showed that she was now identifying with a new family.

This change of clothing marked her transition from her former life to her new place in the community.

Deuteronomy 21:14

dishonored her: When a man first took a woman as a prisoner and later divorced her, he treated her as if she had little value. This action brought shame and pain to her.

To protect her from further harm, the law limited what he could do. He was not allowed to sell her as a slave or treat her like property.

Instead, he had to let her go free.

Deuteronomy 21:15–17

- God's law required that a firstborn son receive the largest share of his father's inheritance (see 21:15–16; 2 Kings 2:9). The custom of giving the firstborn son a double portion is first recorded here but was implied in earlier practice (see Genesis 25:31–34; 27:1–4; 48:8–22).
- that son is the firstfruits of his father's strength: The eldest male child had this special status because he showed that the father could have children, especially a son.

Deuteronomy 21:20

Calling someone a glutton and a drunkard was probably a common saying that implied self-indulgence and laziness. Such a person was seen as worthless, rebelling against both parents and the community, as well as God's authority (see Proverbs 23:20–21).

Deuteronomy 21:22

hang his body on a tree: This was not the method of execution, at least in this text. It was a shameful display of those already put to death for severe crimes punishable by death. This was probably to show the Lord's hatred of sin. It also warned others about committing similar acts (see also Genesis 40:19, 22; Joshua 10:26; 2 Samuel 4:12; 21:12; Esther 2:23; 7:10).

Deuteronomy 21:23

- anyone who is hung (literally a man hung): The ancient Greek version reads for everyone who is hanged on a tree. Compare Galatians 3:13, which explains how this saying applies to Jesus.
- is under God's curse: Sinners who refuse to repent experience God's judgment. But this saying probably means that people would assume God cursed someone in this condition. In reality, the person might have been misjudged or even killed without a legal trial.

Deuteronomy 22:1

you must not ignore it: A person should not avoid a difficult situation by pretending not to see it. Doing so is a failure of the person to do his duty to the covenant community.

Deuteronomy 22:5

In this law, men and women were not to dress or act like the other gender. The command was meant to keep a clear distinction between them.

This instruction reflects a broader pattern in Deuteronomy of keeping certain things separate (also 22:9–11).

Deuteronomy 22:9

with two types of seed: Planting two different kinds of seed in the same field would mix two kinds of plants together.

The law taught that certain things should remain separate. Planting different seeds in one field would go against this principle.

Deuteronomy 22:10

Plowing with an ox and a donkey together would not work well. The two animals are different in size and strength.

This example teaches the principle of separation and order. It shows that certain things should not be joined together (see also 2 Corinthians 6:14–18).

Deuteronomy 22:11

Keeping wool and linen separate showed Israel's separation as God's holy people (see also Leviticus 19:19).

Deuteronomy 22:12

Placing four tassels on the edge of a garment likely reminded the wearer to remain loyal to the covenant.

The tassels served as a visible reminder. They helped the person remember to obey the Lord's instructions (see Numbers 15:37–41).

Deuteronomy 22:14

If a husband found evidence that his wife was not a virgin before marriage, he could accuse her of improper behavior (see 22:15). In that culture, this charge was serious. It brought public shame on the woman and her family.

Deuteronomy 22:15

proof of her virginity: : A blood-stained cloth would show that the woman's hymen was ruptured by her first act of intercourse with her husband.

Deuteronomy 22:17

The cloth (literally covering) may also have been a piece of clothing, such as a night garment.

Deuteronomy 22:19

100 shekels of silver: The husband had already paid the woman's father the normal bride price (a payment made at marriage). Now he must pay more money because he falsely accused her and damaged her reputation.

Deuteronomy 22:21

by being promiscuous (literally acting as a prostitute): One act of sexual intercourse by an unmarried woman was enough for her to receive this shameful label. Under the law, this offense could result in the death penalty.

Deuteronomy 22:24

In the Old Testament, betrothal (a formal promise to marry) was treated like marriage. Because of this, the phrase his neighbor's wife in this passage can refer to a woman who was engaged to be married.

Deuteronomy 22:29

- fifty shekels of silver: The young woman's father could still receive a bride-price for his unmarried daughter (see Genesis 34:12; Exodus 22:16).
- she must become his wife: The law required the man to marry the young woman. However, this assumed that both the young woman and her father agreed to the marriage (see Exodus 22:17).

Deuteronomy 22:30

The phrase his father's wife does not refer to a man's own mother. Sexual relations with one's mother were considered a more serious offense.

Such acts were clearly forbidden in the law of Moses (see Leviticus 18:7–8, 29).

Deuteronomy 23:1

Emasculation is the removal of a man's sexual organs. In the ancient world, it was sometimes linked to pagan rituals and customs. Such practices were deeply offensive to the Lord (compare Isaiah 56:3–4).

Deuteronomy 23:3

- No Ammonite or Moabite: The Ammonites and Moabites were descendants of Lot (see study notes on 2:9, 19). Their origin came from an unlawful family relationship.

Later, these nations refused to let Israel pass through their land during the wilderness journey (23:4).

- The phrase even to the tenth generation does not mean only ten literal generations. It refers to a very long or indefinite period of time.

Deuteronomy 23:4

- Pethor is now identified with Pitru in Mesopotamia (see study note on Numbers 22:5–6).
- Aram-naharaim means "Aram of the two rivers." It was located between the Euphrates River and the Balih River in upper Mesopotamia.

Deuteronomy 23:7

The Edomites were descendants of Jacob's brother, Esau (see 2:8).

Deuteronomy 23:8

third generation: After a waiting period of three generations, Edomites and Egyptians who lived among Israel could join in worship of the Lord.

This time of probation (a period of testing or waiting) came before they were fully accepted into the community of faith.

Deuteronomy 23:10

a nocturnal emission: A nocturnal emission is a discharge of semen that happens during sleep. It may occur without intention or control.

Even though it was not deliberate, it made a man ceremonially unclean (not fit for worship for a time; see Leviticus 15:16–18).

Deuteronomy 23:12

outside the camp: Human waste is a normal bodily function. However, in Israel's law it made a person ritually unclean (not fit for worship for a time).

Because God is holy, the camp had to remain clean. For this reason, people had to go outside the camp when relieving themselves.

Deuteronomy 23:13

It would be unclean and shameful to have an open toilet area near the camp. It would be even worse to have it inside the camp.

Deuteronomy 23:14

anything unclean (literally nakedness of a thing): Because the camp of God's army was holy (set apart for him), the people had to keep it pure. For this reason, no one was to expose private parts of the body inside the camp (compare Genesis 2:25; 3:7–11; 9:21–23; Exodus 20:26; Isaiah 47:3; Revelation 3:18).

Deuteronomy 23:17

A temple prostitute was commonly a part of Canaanite religious ceremonies, but they were forbidden in Israel.

Deuteronomy 23:18

male: The Hebrew word used here literally means "dog." In this context, it was a strong insult. It was used for men who were involved in same-sex acts connected with Canaanite religious practices.

Deuteronomy 23:19–20

The word translated as interest is related to a noun meaning "bite." Charging interest was like "biting" the debtor. See also Exodus 22:25; Leviticus 25:36–37; Nehemiah 5:1–13; Psalm 15:5.

Deuteronomy 23:24

your neighbor's vineyard: In a way, God owned all the land and gave it to people. So, no one could claim it as only theirs.

But renters had rights to privacy and some control over their land. People could enter the land, but not to steal. People could pick a few grapes or grain kernels to eat while passing by (see Matthew 12:1–8; Mark 2:23–28; Luke 6:1–5).

Deuteronomy 24:1

- some indecency: This phrase refers to sexual impurity or another wrongdoing. It does not relate to adultery, which would have required the death penalty (22:22).
- a certificate of divorce: This was a concession. Starting a divorce in such cases was optional and not always preferable (see Malachi 2:16; Matthew 5:31–32; Mark 10:2–12).

Deuteronomy 24:4

- They might call a woman defiled because she had two husbands. Returning to the first husband would be considered adultery.
- sin upon the land: In ancient Israel, community was very important. An individual's identity was closely tied to the community. One person's sin affected the entire community.

Deuteronomy 24:6

that would be taking one's livelihood (literally it is his life): Without his tool, the millstone owner might die. The law set a limit on what could secure a loan. The millstone probably represents any way a person earned a living.

Deuteronomy 24:8

infectious skin diseases: Modern medical research shows that this term does not refer only to leprosy (Hansen's disease).

Instead, it likely describes several kinds of serious skin conditions.

Deuteronomy 24:11

stand outside: Even a person who owed money had to be treated with dignity. The law protected the person from unnecessary shame.

When collecting a debt, the lender had to wait outside. The lender was not allowed to enter the debtor's home and invade the debtor's privacy.

Deuteronomy 24:13

return it to him by sunset: The law was merciful.

Deuteronomy 24:17

Do not deny justice: The people of Israel must actively resist discriminating against the weakest and most vulnerable in society. God had released Israel from a similar status in Egypt. Their experience should guide them in treating others in similar situations (24:18).

Deuteronomy 25:3

During a whipping, the maximum number of strikes allowed was forty lashes. Fewer could be given depending on the situation (25:2). As people created in the image of God, they deserved mercy and respect, even if they did wrong. In later Judaism, they gave thirty-nine lashes (see 2 Corinthians 11:24 and note).

Deuteronomy 25:4

Do not muzzle an ox: The animal had to be able to eat the grain as it worked (compare 1 Corinthians 9:9–14; 1 Timothy 5:17–18).

Deuteronomy 25:5

The phrase fulfill the duty of a brother-in-law refers to the levirate marriage custom. The word levirate comes from a Latin word meaning "brother-in-law."

When a married man died without a son, his brother was encouraged to marry the widow. He would father children in his brother's name so that the dead man's family line would continue. For examples of this custom, see Genesis 38:6–11; Ruth 3:12–13; 4:1–12; Luke 20:27–33.

Deuteronomy 25:9

- remove his sandal: By removing his sandal, which touched the ground, the brother-in-law gave up his right to his dead brother's property. This action showed publicly that he would not carry out his duty (Ruth 4:7).
- spit in his face: Spitting in someone's face was a strong sign of shame and rejection. It showed deep dishonor and contempt (see Numbers 12:14).

Deuteronomy 25:10

his family name in Israel will be called: If a man refused to preserve his brother's name, people would speak about his family with shame.

His household would be known in a negative way because he did not fulfill his duty.

Deuteronomy 25:11–12

cut off her hand: The woman's action would stop the man from having children. Like the earlier law (25:9) the punishment matches the crime. This is called lex talionis ("the law of equal punishment"; see study note on 19:21).

Deuteronomy 25:13–14

You shall not have two differing weights ... one large and one small (Hebrew you must not have stone and stone, large and small, ... ephah and ephah, large and small): Merchants should not use two sets of weights and measures to cheat customers. They should not use a heavier weight when buying goods to pay less or a lighter one when selling to earn more.

Deuteronomy 25:17

The Amalekites were tribal groups who attacked Israel during the journey through the Sinai wilderness. They attacked the back of the camp, where the weak and tired people were traveling (Exodus 17:8–16).

The Amalekites were likely related to the Edomites. Their ancestor was Amalek, a grandson of Esau (Genesis 36:12).

Deuteronomy 25:19

- blot out: God authorized war against his enemies. Later, the prophet Samuel commanded King Saul to completely destroy the Amalekites, something he only partially accomplished (1 Samuel 15). As a result, God rejected Saul as king.
- from under heaven: God commanded the Israelites to completely destroy the Amalekites (see study note on Deuteronomy 2:34).

Deuteronomy 26:1–15

Under the covenant, God required his people to give him tribute every year, or even more often.

Because Israel was an agricultural society, God asked for offerings of animals, crops, or grain.

This tribute celebrated the great redemption of the Israelites during the exodus.

Deuteronomy 26:5

- Jacob's mother, Rebekah, was an Aramean (Genesis 24:10; 25:20, 26). Jacob also lived in Aram for many years (Genesis 31:41–42). His family lived a seminomadic life, moving from place to place.
- few in number: Jacob's family was small. Only 70 people went with him to Egypt (see Genesis 46:27; Exodus 1:5).

Deuteronomy 26:11

In Israelite society, foreigners (literally sojourners) were resident aliens. A resident alien is a person who lives in a land that is not his or her native country. See also study note on 10:18.

Deuteronomy 26:12

Every third year, the people collected the tithe (a tenth of their crops and produce). This tithe was given to the Levites and others who depended on the community for support.

These included people such as foreigners, orphans, and widows. See also study note on 14:28.

Deuteronomy 26:13

I have removed (literally burned) from my house the sacred portion and have given it: The speaker is saying that he has given part of his own property as a sacred

gift. He gave it to the Levites and to others who were in need.

Deuteronomy 26:14

offered any of it for the dead: In some pagan practices, people offered food to the dead. They believed these offerings would help or sustain them.

Such food offerings were not acceptable as part of the tithe. The tithe was to be given to the Levites and not used for these rituals.

Deuteronomy 26:16

with all your heart and with all your soul: This Hebrew phrase clearly refers to the Shema, the foundational statement of Israel's faith and covenant commitment (see 6:4–5 and study notes).

God's expectations were very high and holy. People could not follow them only partway. They had to obey completely, giving their whole effort to God.

Deuteronomy 26:16–19

Moses explained the main covenant principles (chapters 5–11) and clarified their application (chapters 12–26). Then Moses urged the people to obey the covenant with all their hearts.

The Lord had called them into a special relationship with himself, a privilege that required obedience to the covenant prescriptions. The result of this submission was holiness, a state that reflected God's character and that would flow naturally from unbroken fellowship with him.

Deuteronomy 27:3

all the words of this law (all the words of this torah): This phrase might refer to the whole book of Deuteronomy. But considering the small surface on which the text was to be inscribed, it probably just refers to the Ten Commandments (27:2).

Deuteronomy 27:4

The covenant ceremony would happen at Mount Ebal, a mountain east of Shechem (see Joshua 8:30–35). The Samaritan Pentateuch has "Mount Gerizim" here. This is an obvious attempt to justify the existence of the Samaritan temple on that mountain (see Deuteronomy 11:29).

Deuteronomy 27:5

an altar of stones. You must not use any iron tool on them: Archaeological research has found many Canaanite altars made of cut blocks. In contrast, the Israelites were to build their altars only with rough stones from the field (Exodus 20:22–26; see "Altars" Theme Note).

Deuteronomy 27:7

Some offerings were given to atone for sins or trespasses. Others were given to show that the relationship between the Lord and the donor was at peace. For example, peace offerings (also called fellowship offerings) showed that the donor and God were in harmony (see Leviticus 3:1–16).

Deuteronomy 27:9

This day: The Israelites were already the people of God before this moment. But each time Israel confirmed they were God's people and renewed the covenant, they became God's people in a new way. Recommitting to God is like starting a new relationship with him.

Deuteronomy 27:12–26

- Mount Gerizim is just west of Mount Ebal. Shechem is in the valley between them.
- to bless: God positioned the tribes or their representatives carefully. This was so that while the Levites read the covenant from the valley below, the other tribes would respond by shouting "Amen!" This is a Hebrew term that means "May it be so." They said this to show their agreement with the terms of the covenant.

Deuteronomy 27:13

deliver the curse: By calling down curses upon themselves if they disobeyed the covenant terms, these tribes acted as witnesses and judges of their own future disobedience.

Deuteronomy 27:14

God stationed the Levites on Mount Gerizim (27:12). The ark of the covenant was with them, and they offered sacrifices (Joshua 8:30–35). The Levites also taught and proclaimed the Torah (Deuteronomy 33:10; see study note on 6:8; see also Leviticus 10:11).

Deuteronomy 27:15

a carved idol or molten image: To carve or cast an idol means to make a carved image or a metal image for worship.

This act directly violates the second commandment (see 5:7–10). It goes against the covenant ideal, which calls Israel to worship the Lord alone.

Deuteronomy 27:16

dishonors his father or mother: In Israel's understanding, duty to parents came just after duty to God (see 5:16). To treat one's parents with disrespect or disobedience was a serious offense. It closely reflected a lack of respect for God himself.

Deuteronomy 27:17

Moving a boundary marker to increase one's own land is the same as stealing. It takes property that belongs to someone else.

This action clearly breaks the eighth commandment, which says not to steal (see 5:19; 19:14).

Deuteronomy 27:18

blind man: This curse applied not only to a blind person, but to the mistreatment of people with physical disabilities or other disadvantages.

Such cruel behavior was not acceptable for a member of the covenant community (God's people bound by his promises and commands).

Within this community, people were to treat one another fairly and with care.

Deuteronomy 27:19

It would be easy to put foreigners, orphans, and widows at a legal disadvantage or to deny them justice altogether (see 10:18; 24:17).

Deuteronomy 27:20

violated his father's marriage bed: See 22:30.

Deuteronomy 27:22

the daughter of his father or the daughter of his mother: This instruction concerns a relationship with a half-sister or foster sibling. It also forbids a sexual relationship with one's full sibling (see Leviticus 18:9; 20:17).

Deuteronomy 28:1–68

This section explains the conditions for receiving the covenant blessing, the types of blessings, and the curses that will occur if people ignore or disobey these rules (28:1–14; 28:15–68).

Deuteronomy 28:5

The baskets will be blessed because the harvest was successful.

Deuteronomy 28:7

In the Bible, the number seven often shows fullness or completion. In this passage, it means that Israel's enemies would be completely removed from the land (see study note on Deuteronomy 2:34).

Deuteronomy 28:10

When other nations saw Israel's blessings, they would know it was because you are called by the name of the LORD. The nations would think of God and his faithfulness when they saw Israel.

Deuteronomy 28:12

His abundant storehouse: This metaphor describes the clouds that provide life-giving rain to the earth.

Deuteronomy 28:13

the head and not the tail: If Israel obeyed the terms of the covenant, it would lead the nations and not be subject to them.

Deuteronomy 28:17

If Israel disobeyed the commands of the covenant, they could expect God to judge them. One form of judgment would be empty fields and failed crops (compare 28:5).

Deuteronomy 28:21

the plague cling to you: This means the sickness would continue for a long time. It would not leave them until the nation was destroyed.

Deuteronomy 28:22

Some scholars think these symptoms may describe tuberculosis, a serious infectious disease that usually affects the lungs.

Deuteronomy 28:23

This graphic picture of drought and famine shows the sky holding back the rain, which makes the earth dry and barren.

Deuteronomy 28:24

The only thing even resembling rain would be the swirling dust that coats everything to suffocation.

Deuteronomy 28:25

This verse reverses the blessing given in 28:7. Instead of their enemies fleeing in seven directions, Israel would flee in seven directions.

The number seven shows completeness. It means they would be completely defeated and scattered.

Deuteronomy 28:27

- the boils of Egypt: See Exodus 9:8–12.
- tumors: Compare 1 Samuel 5:6, 9, 12.
- scabs: This might refer to a skin condition called dermatitis.
- The itch is also a symptom of dermatitis.

Deuteronomy 28:36

will bring you: This prediction had two major fulfillments in Old Testament times:

- the Assyrian exile of Samaria in 722 BC, and
- the Babylonian conquest and exile of Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Deuteronomy 28:43

foreigner (literally sojourner): This refers to foreigners who lived among Israel but did not own land.

In God's day of judgment, those who were usually seen as weak or vulnerable in society would become stronger and rise above others (see 29:11).

Deuteronomy 28:44

the head ... the tail: To be the head means to lead. To be the tail means to follow.

Instead of leading other nations, Israel would be ruled by them when God punished his people (see 28:13).

Deuteronomy 28:46

a sign and a wonder: This phrase refers to God's mighty acts. These acts draw attention and show his power and authority (see 6:22). They are meant to cause deep fear and respect among his people.

Deuteronomy 28:48

Ancient writings and artwork sometimes show an iron yoke. A yoke was a wooden bar placed on the neck of animals to control them.

Iron is hard and does not bend easily. The image of an iron yoke shows how harsh and severe Israel's slavery would be if the people did not repent.

Deuteronomy 28:49

- like an eagle: This comparison shows how quickly the enemy would attack. Just as a bird of prey swoops down suddenly, the invading army would come without warning.
- whose language you will not understand: The enemy would speak a foreign language that Israel did not know. The Assyrians and Babylonians spoke dialects of Akkadian.

Akkadian was related to Hebrew, but it was very different in grammar, syntax, and vocabulary (see Isaiah 36:11–13).

Deuteronomy 28:50

The Assyrians were known for harsh treatment of their defeated enemies. They showed little mercy.

One method of execution was impalement. They placed victims on a sharp stake while they were still alive (see Isaiah 33:19; Nahum 2:1–7).

Deuteronomy 28:54

gentle and refined man: He had lived a protected life. He had been kept away from suffering and hardship.

He had never faced the terrible events that would soon come upon him.

Deuteronomy 28:56

not ... set ... on the ground: This woman was very delicate and careful. She would not even walk barefoot on the ground.

Deuteronomy 28:57

afterbirth: This terrible scene describes a mother who becomes so hungry that she eats the placenta (the organ that supports a baby before birth) and the baby she has just given birth to.

Deuteronomy 28:58

- The context suggests that all the words of this instruction refers to the entire book of Deuteronomy. In this book, the blessings and curses form a major section (see 27:3).
- If you are not careful ... that you may fear this ... name: To fear the name means to fear God himself. It refers to showing deep respect and reverence for the Lord (see study note on 7:21).

Deuteronomy 28:60

The diseases of Egypt were not just general plagues but those associated with physical illness (see Exodus 9:8–12).

Deuteronomy 28:64

other gods: This phrase does not mean that other gods truly exist. The Old Testament teaches that there is only one God, the Lord.

However, the surrounding nations worshiped other gods. The danger was that Israel might follow their practices and turn away from the Lord.

Deuteronomy 28:68

- The warning about being sent back to Egypt points to any future exile of God's people. It would reverse the exodus, moving them from freedom back into slavery.
- no one will buy you: The disobedient Israelites would be treated as having little value. They would not even be able to sell themselves as slaves.

This stands in sharp contrast to the past. The Lord had redeemed Israel from slavery at great cost (see 9:26).

Deuteronomy 29:1

The land of Moab was the region east of the Jordan River. This was the place where Moses spoke the words recorded in the book of Deuteronomy to the people of Israel.

Deuteronomy 29:2–30.20

As Moses prepared to die, he spoke a farewell message to Israel. In this message, he briefly reviewed their history since they left Egypt.

He urged the nation to promise loyalty to the Lord. This part of Deuteronomy shows that grace (God's undeserved favor) is not only a New Testament teaching. Grace is the foundation of the Lord's relationship with Israel.

Deuteronomy 29:6

but he provided for you: This clause does not appear in the Hebrew but is implied by its context.

Deuteronomy 29:7

- King Sihon of Heshbon, ruler of the Amorites, had controlled an area from the Arnon River to the Ammonite border. See Numbers 21:31–35.
- Heshbon: See Deuteronomy 1:4; 2:24.
- King Og of Bashan had ruled an Amorite kingdom east of the Sea of Galilee (see 3:1).

Deuteronomy 29:8

Reuben, Gad, and half the tribe of Manasseh asked to live in the land east of the Jordan River. Moses agreed and gave them that land (see 3:12–13).

Deuteronomy 29:11

- foreigners (literally sojourner): This word refers to people who lived among Israel but were not native Israelites. See study note on 10:18.
- The phrase cut your wood and draw your water was a common saying for low-level or servant work (see Joshua 9:22–27).

Deuteronomy 29:12

The technical phrase to enter into the covenant meant accepting the terms of the agreement.

Deuteronomy 29:15

those who are not here today: The covenant made with the generation of Moses also included future generations. It was not only for the people alive at that time.

The future descendants of Abraham would share in the covenant's privileges. However, each generation would need to obey the covenant personally in order to receive its blessings (see 4:9).

Deuteronomy 29:17

- the abominations: These practices were deeply offensive forms of pagan worship. They were especially connected to false religious ceremonies (see 7:25–26; 12:31; 13:14).
- idols: The Hebrew word for idols means "round things." It may also suggest something like dung.

This word shows strong disgust. The idols were compared to waste to show how offensive they were.

Deuteronomy 29:18

This metaphor describes idolatry as a root. If allowed to grow, it would lead to idol worship, which is the bitter fruit.

Deuteronomy 29:19

Being careless or overly confident about God's judgment would lead to complete ruin.

Deuteronomy 29:20

blot out his name: If a people's name was removed, they would eventually be forgotten. Their memory and identity would disappear.

The greatest tragedy would be for God to treat Israel as if they had never existed (see 7:24; Exodus 32:32–33; 2 Kings 14:27).

Deuteronomy 29:21

Book of the Law: Here, this phrase refers to the entire book of Deuteronomy. The book includes a long list of curses (chapter 28) that would come upon Israel if they disobeyed the covenant is part of it (see 27:3).

Deuteronomy 29:23

like ... Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim: During the time of Abraham and Lot, God destroyed these cities because of their extreme immorality. Their destruction involved fiery sulfur and salt (Genesis 19:23–28).

Deuteronomy 29:25–28

This explanation anticipates a future when people would look back at Israel's history of rebellion and easily understand why they were in exile.

Deuteronomy 29:27

The phrase this book refers at least to the book of Deuteronomy. It may also refer to the first five books of the Old Testament. These five books are called the Pentateuch (the first five books of the Bible: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy).

Deuteronomy 29:29

- secret things: There seems to be a tension between God's covenant promises to Israel and Israel's exile from the land. God had promised to bless his people. Yet they were sent away from the land because of their sin.

Why would this happen? What purpose could there be in such events? The full answer belongs to God alone.

- the words of this law: See 4:44; 27:3.

Deuteronomy 30:1

the blessings and curses: See 27:1–28:68.

Deuteronomy 30:1–10

Repentance was the only solution to the threat of judgment. The possibility of blessing and the prevention of judgment both depended on a proper relationship with the Lord.

Deuteronomy 30:2–3

with all your heart and all your soul: These words reflect the teaching found in the Shema (Israel's great statement of covenant faith and commitment). The Shema calls Israel to love the Lord fully and faithfully (compare 6:4).

To receive God's forgiveness and return to the land, the people had to obey the covenant. Obedience was required before restoration could take place.

Deuteronomy 30:6

circumcise your heart: This change would be a work of God. It would begin with his grace (his undeserved kindness).

As a result, Israel would experience renewal (a new spiritual beginning). This change would show that the nation truly belonged to the Lord (see 10:16; Jeremiah 4:4; Romans 4:1–12).

Deuteronomy 30:11

This commandment refers to the entire covenant text, which includes all of Deuteronomy (see 4:2; 5:29; 7:9).

Deuteronomy 30:11–20

Obeying the covenant commands that Moses gave would lead to life. Disobeying them would lead to death.

Here, life and death refer to physical life in the land. This applied both to individual people and to the whole community of Israel.

Deuteronomy 30:12

not in heaven: God's revelation (what he has made known) is not hidden in heaven. It is not known only to God.

Instead, God has made his will accessible to human beings. People can hear it and respond to it (see Romans 10:6–8).

Deuteronomy 30:13

not beyond the sea: God's purposes are not controlled by distant nations. They are not kept far away from his people.

Instead, God has made his will known to his people. They can receive it and obey it (see Romans 10:6–8).

Deuteronomy 30:14

The message of salvation is very near you. It is in your mouth, which means it can be spoken and shared. It is in your heart, which means it can be understood and believed.

Because it is near, it can be taught and learned (see 6:6–7).

Deuteronomy 30:16

love the LORD your God: This statement repeats the teaching of the Shema, Israel's central statement of covenant faith (see 6:5). To love God means to obey him in every area of life. Such obedience leads to God's blessing.

Deuteronomy 30:19

life and death, blessing and cursing: This pairing of words shows a close connection. Life is connected to blessing, and death is connected to curse.

In this passage, blessing does not only bring life. Blessing is life itself. It is life in the land, safety, and God's favor.

In the same way, curse does not only bring death. Curse is death itself. It is loss of the land, suffering, and separation from God's favor.

Deuteronomy 30:20

He is your life: In its fullest meaning, life means complete commitment to the Lord.

Deuteronomy 31:1

Based on the context, these instructions refers to all of Deuteronomy (see 1:1).

Deuteronomy 31:1–8

Because Moses was about to die, his role as leader of the covenant would soon end. Joshua needed to be clearly and publicly presented as the next leader. He was to receive the same authority as Moses.

Deuteronomy 31:1–29

For a covenant document to remain binding and important, it had to be kept in a place where both sides could easily find it.

The book of Deuteronomy needed to be preserved for future generations. In this way, Israel would continue to remember to submit to the Lord's rule.

Deuteronomy 31:3

- The LORD ... will cross over ahead of you: God would lead the conquest. The divine warrior, the LORD God of Israel, would command and lead the conflict (see 1:30).
- From the early days of wandering in Sinai until now, Joshua served as the assistant of Moses (Exodus 17:8). God now chose him to be the leader of Israel after Moses (see Deuteronomy 1:38; 3:23–29; Numbers 27:15–23).

Deuteronomy 31:4

Sihon and Og: See study note on 2:24 and Numbers 21:21–35.

Deuteronomy 31:6

He will never leave you nor forsake you: These words encouraged Israel as they prepared to enter the promised land.

They also express a general truth about God's care for his people. He remains faithful and does not leave them (see also Hebrews 13:5).

Deuteronomy 31:9

ark of the covenant of the LORD: This gold-plated wooden chest held the two stone tablets with the Ten Commandments. It was also God's throne, as he sat there invisibly among his people (see study note on 10:1).

Deuteronomy 31:9–13

To remind future generations in Israel of their covenant obligations, they read the covenant text in front of the people. This was necessary because personal copies of documents were rare.

Deuteronomy 31:10

- The year of remission of debt was the seventh year of the calendar, not the seventh year of a specific transaction between people. All debts were cancelled, and Hebrew bond servants were released from their creditors (see 15:1–3).
- Feast of Tabernacles: People celebrated this feast in the seventh month each year (Hebrew Tishri, September/October). It celebrated God's miraculous protection of Israel in the wilderness. It also celebrated the fall harvest (see 16:13–15).

Deuteronomy 31:12

Even foreigners living with the Israelites had to follow the covenant law. Even though they were in a weak and disadvantaged position, the Lord promised to care for them and meet their needs (see 10:18).

Deuteronomy 31:14

Tent of Meeting: At first, the Tent of Meeting was a temporary place where God met with his people, especially Moses. Later, the term came to mean the

tabernacle itself (see Exodus 28:43; 33:7–11; 40:2; Numbers 11:16, 24, 26; 12:4). See study note on Leviticus 1:1.

Deuteronomy 31:15

Since God is Spirit, people cannot see him unless he chooses to show his glory physically. The pillar of cloud was one such display, sometimes called a theophany (see study note on 1:33). When the pillar appeared, those who saw it recognized God's presence (see Exodus 33:9; Numbers 12:5).

Deuteronomy 31:18

I will surely hide my face: The invisible God used this expression to show the broken relationship between himself and his people (see study note on 8:2). He turned away to show his rejection and disapproval.

Deuteronomy 31:19–22

In the future, when the community sings this song, it will remind them of God's past faithfulness and their frequent disloyalty (32:1–43). The song includes major blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience. The people of Israel will sing it to show they accept these promises and warnings. Through music, they will remember God's blessings for obedience and call for God's judgment if they are unfaithful.

Deuteronomy 31:20

- land flowing with milk and honey: See study note on 6:3.
- eat their fill: Fatness suggested blessing and prosperity, not obesity or self-indulgence.
- reject me: Israel would ignore God and dishonor him by wrongly thinking their prosperity came from their own efforts or the false gods of the land.

Deuteronomy 31:22

Moses wrote down this song: This statement supports the traditional view that Moses wrote the book of Deuteronomy (see Deuteronomy Book Introduction, "Authorship").

Deuteronomy 31:23

I will be with you: God spoke these same words to Moses at the burning bush when he called him to lead Israel out of Egypt (Exodus 3:12).

Now God spoke the same promise to Joshua. The same God who was with Moses would also be with Joshua, and he could bring about the same kind of success.

Deuteronomy 31:26

- beside the ark: Unlike the stone tablets, they must place the scroll of Deuteronomy near the ark of the covenant, not inside it. It was kept in the inner sanctuary of the tabernacle and later in the temple (see 31:9; Exodus 25:16; 26:33).
- a witness: Like the song the Israelites were required to sing, the scroll of Deuteronomy served as a constant reminder of Israel's covenant obligations and privileges (see Deuteronomy 31:19; see 31:10, 19).

Deuteronomy 31:30–32.47

In ancient times, vows from both parties secured a treaty between individuals or nations. Israel's promise was in a song of witness that Moses composed under divine inspiration (31:19–22).

Israel probably sang the song during a regular covenant-renewal ceremony (31:21). They invoked upon themselves the covenant's judgments and reminded themselves of its promises.

Deuteronomy 32:1

Give ear, O heavens ... hear, O earth: Moses called on the witnesses of the covenant to observe Israel's confession and commitment, as well as its expected disobedience and disloyalty (see 30:19).

Deuteronomy 32:2

like rain ... like dew: This comparison shows how gentle and life-giving the teaching of Moses should be. Rain and dew softly water the ground and help plants grow.

In the same way, the words of Moses should refresh God's people. His teaching should help obedience grow in their hearts.

Deuteronomy 32:4

the Rock: This metaphor represents the Lord as strong, stable, and reliable. God is more than capable of providing righteousness and justice (see 32:15, 18, 30; Habakkuk 1:12).

Deuteronomy 32:7

Ask your father: History teaches those who are willing to listen and learn. God wanted his people to remember what he had done in the past.

In the wisdom tradition of the Old Testament, fathers had the responsibility to teach their children. They passed on the lessons that they themselves had received (see, for example, Proverbs 1:8; 2:1; 3:1).

Deuteronomy 32:8

- God is sovereign over all nations and cares about them. He has given them their lands for his own reasons (see Psalm 74:17; Acts 17:26).
- the Most High (Hebrew ‘Elyon): Abraham learned this name for God when he met Melchizedek (Genesis 14:19). This ancient name shows that God rules over all. It describes his universal sovereignty, which means that he has authority over every nation and every part of creation.
- the boundaries: One sign of God’s sovereignty was how he gave lands to the nations (see Genesis 10).

Deuteronomy 32:9

His allotted inheritance: God called Israel his son, whom he released from slavery in Egypt (see Exodus 4:22–23; 13:15; Deuteronomy 7:6).

Deuteronomy 32:14

rams from Bashan, and goats: This high plateau east of the Sea of Galilee was famous for its livestock (see study note on 1:4; see also Psalm 22:12; Ezekiel 39:18; Amos 4:1).

Deuteronomy 32:15

- Jeshurun: This name probably comes from a verb meaning “to be upright.” It shows the Lord’s strong love for his people (see 33:5, 26; Isaiah 44:2).
- the Rock: This metaphor describes God’s strength and reliability, especially in salvation (see Deuteronomy 32:4).

Deuteronomy 32:16

His jealousy: See study note on 4:24. Just as a husband is rightfully jealous when another man tries to take his wife away, God was jealous when Israel worshiped other gods (Proverbs 6:34).

Deuteronomy 32:17

- demons: In the ancient Near East, people believed gods protected individuals and places from harm. But, worshiping these pagan gods was actually worshiping evil spirits (compare 1 Corinthians 10:20–21; Revelation 9:20).
- newly arrived gods: These were false gods that Israel had never before encountered.

Deuteronomy 32:18

the Rock: This phrase emphasizes God’s reliability as Father (see 32:4, 9).

Deuteronomy 32:20

The phrase children of unfaithfulness indicates disloyalty to the covenant. Israel had promised to be true to the Lord but had consistently been unfaithful (see Exodus 19:8).

Deuteronomy 32:21

- provoked My jealousy: The Lord was not upset because people paid attention to false gods. Israel had broken their covenant by worshiping other gods. This showed their disrespect for God and his authority (see 32:16).
- those who are not a people: God’s plan for Israel was not only to save them, but also to save all nations through them. Israel often saw other nations as worthless. By showing care for other nations, God would lead Israel back to obedience (see Hosea 1:9; 2:23; Romans 9:25; 10:19).

Deuteronomy 32:22

depths of Sheol: People believed that the place of the dead was deep underground. The grave was its entrance. God is everywhere, and his judgment reaches even the most hidden places (see Psalm 139:7–12).

Deuteronomy 32:27

if I had not dreaded: God is never terrified or intimidated. This fear is concern that Israel’s enemies would attribute their success to their own efforts rather than to God’s sovereign judgment of his people (see Exodus 32:11–14).

Deuteronomy 32:29

their fate (literally their latter end): God had not made a final decision on Israel’s future. This statement expresses what would happen if Israel kept rebelling.

Deuteronomy 32:30

- How could one man pursue a thousand: When God allows his people to face destruction, they can be defeated even against great odds.
- their Rock: This metaphor is used ironically. The very one who should be Israel’s source of strength will leave them because of their own sin and unfaithfulness (see 32:4).

Deuteronomy 32:31

their rock: In this sarcastic comparison, Moses contrasts the pagan gods with the Lord, the God of Israel. The word rock refers to a place of safety and strength.

The false gods of the nations were not truly strong or able to save. In comparison, the Lord alone is powerful and faithful. The pagan gods fall far short of him.

Deuteronomy 32:32

Sodom ... Gomorrah: These cities became well-known examples of extreme evil (see Genesis 18:16–19:38). They showed deep moral corruption and rejected God.

Because the people refused to turn from their sin, God completely destroyed the cities (see Deuteronomy 29:23). Sodom and Gomorrah became lasting warnings of what happens when people continue in wickedness without repentance.

Deuteronomy 32:34

Metaphorically, My vaults refers to a storage place. It pictures God as a divine warrior (a king who fights for his people). In this image, God stores his weapons and tools for judgment in a treasury.

He keeps them ready until the right time to use them (see 1:30).

Deuteronomy 32:36

will change his mind about: When speaking of God, the Old Testament frequently uses figurative language (see study note on 8:2). Human beings cannot understand God's mind (Isa 55:8), so God uses human language and gives himself human physical characteristics and feelings. Although the Bible frequently speaks of God's eyes, arms, hands, and feet, he is invisible and has no body; these metaphors describe his activity. Similarly, when the Bible says that God fears (Deut 32:27) or changes his mind, it expresses how God's actions appear to humans.

Deuteronomy 32:37

the rock: This is a sarcastic metaphor. A metaphor compares one thing to another in order to make a point.

Here, rocks refers to pagan gods. The image highlights their impotence (lack of power). Unlike the Lord, these gods cannot act or save. (see 32:31).

Deuteronomy 32:38

ate the fat ... drank the wine: Many religions that believed in more than one god thought that the gods were nourished by the sacrifices people offered. For a time, Israel also followed this false idea. Later, the Lord taught them the truth and restored them to himself (32:36).

Deuteronomy 32:40

I lift up My hand to heaven: This way of speaking about God as if he had human actions (anthropomorphism; see study notes on 4:34 and 8:2) shows that God is serious about keeping his covenant promises to rescue his people from their enemies. When God makes an oath, he is not relying on any external force in case he fails. Instead, the statement emphasizes that God's promises are completely reliable, beyond even his character (see Numbers 14:21, 28; Isaiah 49:18; Ezekiel 20:5–6).

Deuteronomy 32:42

The phrase arrows drunk with blood uses figurative language. It gives human qualities to arrows, as if they could drink. It also uses exaggeration to show how great the destruction will be.

This picture shows how severe God's judgment on the nations will be. The language is strong to help the listener understand the seriousness of the coming punishment.

Deuteronomy 32:47

- they are your life: Obeying the Lord's words brings life (see 8:3; 30:20).
- you will live long: This promise does not guarantee each person will live for a long time or become immortal. It refers to Israel's extended stay in the promised land.

Deuteronomy 32:49

The mountains east of the river refer to a mountain range that looks down over the Jordan Valley. These mountains stand on the east side of the Jordan River.

Mount Nebo is a well-known peak in this range. From Mount Nebo, Moses could see the land of Canaan to the west. He also died there (32:50; see 3:17).

Deuteronomy 32:50

- The exact location of Mount Hor is not certain. Many people identify it with Jebel Haroun. This traditional site is near the Nabatean city of Petra (see Numbers 20:22–29).
- The phrase gathered to his people is a gentle way to speak about death and burial. It means that the person died and was buried with earlier family members.

Deuteronomy 32:51

you broke faith with Me: During the journey in the wilderness, Moses dishonored the Lord by striking a

rock to get water. This act of impatience and anger prevented Moses from entering the promised land (Numbers 20:1–13; see Deuteronomy 1:37; 3:26–27).

Deuteronomy 33:1–29

On the day before he died, Jacob blessed his 12 sons (Genesis 49:1–28). Many years later, Moses also blessed these same sons. By that time, they had become large and powerful tribes. Moses, like Jacob, spoke as a founding father of the nation.

Deuteronomy 33:2

- This poetic passage does not describe an exact travel route that God followed. Instead, it uses vivid language to show God's greatness. It pictures God coming at certain times and places to lead his people in battle against their enemies. This is sometimes described as God's war, meaning that God fought on behalf of his people.
- Mount Paran refers to the highlands of Paran in the northeast part of the Sinai Peninsula (see 1:1).

Deuteronomy 33:3

- In covenant settings, to love often means "to choose." The Lord truly loves his people. But in this context, it means that he chose them as his special possession (4:20).
- Your hand: This phrase uses a picture to show safety. It means that Israel, called his holy ones, was secure in the Lord's care.
- his steps: To follow the Lord means "to live as he teaches and to go where he leads." It describes a way of life that matches his ways.
- Your words: This refers especially to the Torah. The Torah is the law that God gave to Israel. It includes all of his instructions for their life together.

Deuteronomy 33:4

of Jacob: The Hebrew probably uses Jacob because the tribes descended from Jacob's 12 sons are here listed by name as recipients of God's blessing (33:6–25; compare Genesis 49:1–28).

Deuteronomy 33:6

Reuben was Jacob's oldest son by Leah (see Genesis 29:32). His sin against his father might explain why his tribe did not become very important (Genesis 35:22; 49:3–4).

Deuteronomy 33:7

Judah was Jacob's fourth son with Leah (Genesis 29:35). The Messiah (God's chosen one) would come from this tribe.

This promise was fulfilled first in David (Ruth 4:18–22; 1 Chronicles 2:3–15) and then in Jesus Christ (Matthew 1:1–6a; see Genesis 49:10).

Deuteronomy 33:8

- Levi was Jacob's third son by Leah (Genesis 29:34). His descendants were called Levites. The Levites, especially those descended from Aaron, were given responsibility for the priesthood (see Exodus 28:1; 32:29; Numbers 3:9).
- Thummim ... Urim: These were precious stones placed in or attached to the breastpiece of the ephod (a special garment worn by the chief priest). The stones were used to seek God's will. Their names may mean "perfections" and "lights" (see study note on Exodus 28:30).
- Massah means "[place of] testing." This refers to the time the people ran out of water and tested the Lord (see study note on Deuteronomy 6:16; Exodus 17:1–7).
- Meribah means "[place of] contention." This refers to the time the Israelites argued with the Lord until he provided water from a rock (Numbers 20:13, 24).

Deuteronomy 33:9

maintained Your covenant: This verse refers to the sin of the gold calf at Mount Sinai and to what happened at Baal-peor (Exodus 32:25–29; Numbers 25:6–9). At those times, the Levites chose to stand with the Lord.

Their love for the Lord and their loyalty to his covenant (his binding agreement with his people) were stronger than their loyalty to their own families. Because of this, God did not destroy the whole nation. Instead, the Levites received the special honor described here.

Deuteronomy 33:10

- He will teach Your ordinances ... law: Besides performing priestly duties like sacrifices and assisting at the Tent of Meeting and the temple, the Levites were responsible for teaching the Torah (31:9–13).
- set incense: Only Levitical priests could perform this ministry (Numbers 16:39–40). Later, when King Uzziah entered the temple to offer incense, he was strongly condemned. He was arrogant in violating what was only the privilege of the priests. He suffered from a skin disease for the rest of his life (2 Chronicles 26:16–21).

Deuteronomy 33:12

Benjamin was Jacob's youngest son (Genesis 35:18; 49:27). Rachel was Jacob's favorite wife, so he favored Benjamin. God blessed Benjamin's tribe with special protection.

Deuteronomy 33:13–17

Joseph was Jacob's eleventh son and his favorite child (Genesis 30:23–24; Genesis 37:3). Joseph and his two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, received Jacob's special blessing (Genesis 48; 49:22–26). Because of this, the tribes of Joseph prospered and multiplied. They became two separate tribes.

Deuteronomy 33:16

- Him who dwelt in the burning bush: See Exodus 3:2–4. The same God who rescued Israel from slavery blessed the tribes of Joseph.
- the prince of his brothers: Joseph's dream of ruling over his siblings came true when they submitted to him in Egypt (Genesis 37:5–11; 42:6).

Deuteronomy 33:17

Ephraim is listed first because he received the blessing of the firstborn instead of Manasseh (Genesis 48:8–22). Manasseh was the older son. Normally, the firstborn son received a double portion of the inheritance (compare Deuteronomy 21:17). However, Jacob gave this special blessing to Ephraim, Joseph's younger son.

The blessing of Moses follows the same pattern. He describes Ephraim as having myriads (literally tens of thousands) and Manasseh as having thousands. This shows greater strength and growth for Ephraim.

After Israel conquered the land and became a nation, Ephraim became the leading tribe in the north. Later, after Solomon died and the kingdom divided (1 Kings 12), the name Ephraim was often used to mean the northern kingdom of Israel.

Deuteronomy 33:18

- Zebulun and Issachar were the sixth and fifth sons born to Jacob by Leah (Genesis 30:18, 20).
- in your journeys ... in your tents: This phrase uses a figure of speech called a merism (a way of speaking that uses two opposite ideas to mean "everything in between"). Here, it describes the whole of life. It includes times of movement and work (journeys) and times of rest at home (tents).

Deuteronomy 33:19

- to a mountain: The tribe of Issachar received much of the plain of Jezreel, also called Esdraelon. Mount Tabor was an important mountain in this area. It was likely the mountain being referred to here. Later tradition says this mountain was a place of worship (Hosea 5:1).

We do not know exactly what kind of worship took place there. However, it was probably proper worship, even though it did not happen at the temple in Jerusalem (see 1 Kings 18:30, 32).

- The phrase the abundance of the sea might refer to trade and fishing. The tribe of Zebulun may have benefited from the sea when their western border reached the Mediterranean Sea(see Genesis 49:13).

Deuteronomy 33:20

Gad was the older of two sons born to Jacob by Leah's servant Zilpah (Genesis 30:10–11). His name means "good fortune."

However, the main idea is that the one who helps the tribe gain more land is the truly fortunate one. The tribe of Gad settled east of the Jordan River and the Sea of Galilee.

Deuteronomy 33:21

The tribe of Gad chose this territory before the conquest of Canaan. It was the rich and productive land of Bashan (Numbers 32:1–5).

God praises Gad for carrying out his justice and obeying his rules. This probably refers to the tribe's faithfulness in helping the western tribes conquer Canaan (Joshua 22:1–3).

Deuteronomy 33:22

Dan was the older of two sons born to Jacob by Rachel's servant Bilhah (Genesis 30:5–6). His name means "he judged."

The tribe of Dan first received land between Judah and the Mediterranean Sea (Joshua 19:40–48). However, the people who already lived there strongly opposed them. Because of this, the tribe of Dan could not settle in that area.

Later, the tribe moved far to the north. They attacked the people living in Laish, destroyed the city, and settled there. This new land was near Mount Hermon, north of the Sea of Galilee, and next to Bashan (Judges 18:27–28).

The Bible does not clearly say where Dan gathered its army before attacking Laish. However, the phrase

leaping out of Bashan may suggest that the attack began from Bashan (see Genesis 49:16–17).

Deuteronomy 33:23

- Naphtali was the younger of two sons of Jacob by Rachel's servant Bilhah (Genesis 30:7–8). His name means "my struggle."
- the sea and the south: The Hebrew word yam can mean either "west" or "sea." It may describe the area where the tribe of Naphtali settled. They lived near the Sea of Galilee, a region known for fishing and farming (see Matthew 4:12–17.

Deuteronomy 33:24

Asher was the younger of two sons of Jacob by Leah's servant Zilpah (Genesis 30:12–13). The name Asher means "happy" or "blessed." This is evident in the plentiful olive oil from the orchards on the lower Galilean hills and Mount Carmel. These hills and other natural formations also provided safety from danger (Deuteronomy 33:25).

Deuteronomy 33:26

who rides the heavens: Moses finished blessing the tribes by praising the Lord. Like a powerful warrior, God rides victoriously through the skies on chariots of clouds (see 1:30).

Deuteronomy 33:27

God's everlasting arms represent his eternal nature. This means God has always existed and always will. They also represent his power and care. God's power would remove the Canaanites from the promised land, allowing Israel to enter and settle there.

Deuteronomy 33:29

trample their high places: This means having complete victory over an enemy. The word high places refers to the heights of the land and traditional pagan worship sites. This suggests total physical and spiritual conquest. The Lord promised to lead the way and guarantee success in the upcoming conquest (see 11:24–25; Joshua 1:3; 14:9; compare Amos 4:13; Micah 1:3; Habakkuk 3:15).

Deuteronomy 34:1

- Mount Nebo is a high point in the Abarim hills east of the Jordan River. From here, you can see almost all the land west of the Jordan River (32:49).
- Nebo was part of Pisgah peak (see study note on 3:17).
- Gilead as far as Dan: This was the northernmost part of the land. The Sea of Galilee and Mount Hermon are directly north of Nebo. Gilead is east of the sea, and Dan (also called Laish; Judges 18:29) was south and west of Hermon.

Deuteronomy 34:1–12

Moses did not enter the promised land (see study note on 32:51). However, God allowed him to share a moment of glory in the land when the divine glory of Jesus was revealed to others (Luke 9:28–36).

Deuteronomy 34:2

The land of Naphtali was northwest of Nebo and west of the Sea of Galilee.

The land of Ephraim and Manasseh included a large area to the west-northwest of Nebo, in what is now the West Bank area of Palestine.

The land of Judah was directly west-southwest of Nebo, extending from the Jordan River to the Mediterranean Sea.

Deuteronomy 34:3

- Negev means "desert" or "south." It is a desert region that stretches from Judah to the Gulf of Eilat (or Aqaba). It extends to the far southwest of Mount Nebo.
- Jericho ... to Zoar: These sites marked the northern and southern ends of the Jordan valley from the viewpoint on Mount Nebo.

Zoar was a city on the plain that God did not destroy during Abraham and Lot's time (see Genesis 19:21–22, 30).

Deuteronomy 34:6

- Beth-peor is where Israel took part in pagan ceremonies (see 3:29; 4:3; Numbers 25). It is also where Moses gave his farewell speech (see Deuteronomy 4:44–46).
- The phrase to this day refers to the time of Deuteronomy's final composition (see Genesis Book Introduction, "Authorship").

Deuteronomy 34:7

At 120 years old, Moses was still strong and fully able in mind and body. He did not fail to enter Canaan because he died. Instead, he died because he was not allowed to enter Canaan.

Deuteronomy 34:9

filled with the spirit of wisdom: God chose Joshua to lead Israel after Moses died. Joshua needed the Spirit of God in order to be Israel's leader (Numbers 27:15–23; compare Numbers 11:16–30).

After Moses died, God showed that Joshua was his divinely chosen successor by giving clear evidence of the Spirit's power and blessing.

Deuteronomy 34:10

face to face: Moses and the Lord had a very close relationship. There was no need for another person to stand between them.

At one time, Aaron and Miriam questioned the leadership of Moses. The Lord strongly corrected them (Numbers 12:8). He reminded them that they were prophets who received messages from God through dreams and visions. Moses was different.

God said, "I speak with him face to face, clearly and not in riddles" (12:8). No other prophet in Old Testament times had the same kind of relationship with God (see study note on Deuteronomy 18:15).

Deuteronomy 34:12

awesome deeds ... in the sight of all Israel: The people of Israel saw the mighty acts that God performed. The Egyptians also saw his power. These events caused fear and awe.

The people needed to remember God's power. This would help them obey him with reverent fear (see 4:10; 5:29; 6:2; Proverbs 1:7).